

Reading Edition

The whole play, line by line — and before each line, what it means and what is moving underneath it. Six Characters in Search of an Author · Village Players, Lausanne · dir. Kiarash Jamshidi

HOW TO USE IT

- **Every spoken line carries a note** — the short italic line set just above it, marked by a gold rule. It says what the line is really doing: the intent, the subtext, the move beneath the words.
- **The line itself follows, in full.** Stage directions are set in italic between the speeches, as in the script.
- **Read it straight through** to follow the play with its undertow exposed, or dip into any part — the notes are written to stand on their own.
- The notes read the play through this production's lens: the Father who turns guilt into philosophy, the Step-Daughter who uses truth as a weapon, the Mother as the silent centre of pain, the Son who refuses to be staged, the Manager who becomes the audience's complicity, and the company who stop laughing.

Act One — The Family

PART I — THE REHEARSAL

The spectators will find the curtain raised and the stage as it usually is during the day time. It will be half dark, and empty, so that from the beginning the public may have the impression of an impromptu performance. Prompter's box and a small table and chair for the manager.

Two other small tables and several chairs scattered about as during rehearsals.

*The **Actors** and **Actresses** of the company enter from the back of the stage: first one, then another, then two together; nine or ten in all. They are about to rehearse a Pirandello play: *Mixing it Up*. [Il giuoco delle parti.] Some of the company move off towards their dressing rooms. The **Prompter** who has the "book" under his arm, is waiting for the manager in order to begin the rehearsal.*

*The **Players**, some standing, some sitting, chat in two languages and check their phones. One scrolls yesterday's 24 heures; another mutters her lines under her breath. Somebody, in the wings, is making coffee.*

*Finally, the **Manager** enters with the precise weariness of a man who has been managing the Village Players for too long. He goes to the table prepared for him. His **Secretary** brings him his mail, through which he glances with the expression of one who has never, in his life, received good news from an envelope. The **Prompter** takes his seat, turns on a light, and opens the "book."*

The Manager's opening gesture frames authority through theatrical irritation — letters, darkness, and borrowed light signal a company running on empty.

THE MANAGER *[throwing the morning's letter onto the table].* I can't see a thing in here. *[To **Property Man**.]* A little light, please — if the house has any left to spare us this evening.

Her body has already been working while management sleeps; the forward weight signals readiness that earns no acknowledgment.

PLAYER 2 (AS PROPERTY MAN) *[she has been at work for an hour; the Property Man's bearing — shoulders forward, weight on the front foot].* Yes, sir. At once. *[A light comes down on to the stage.]*

The clapping hands perform command while the parenthetical betrayal — 'if you wanted the public to come back' — reveals how little he trusts his own company.

THE MANAGER *[clapping his hands].* Come along! Come along! Second act of "Mixing It Up" — and try, this time, to play it as if you wanted the public to come back for the third. *[Sits down.]* *[The **Actors** and **Actresses** go from the front of the stage to the wings, all except the three who are to begin the rehearsal.]*

Vanity wrapped in nostalgia: he inserts himself into a stage direction, reminding no one in particular that he once mattered.

PLAYER 1 (AS LEADING MAN) *[settling himself, to no one].* The public came back for the third act once. I was in it.

The Prompter reads a fictional domestic space into being — the mundane room will soon be invaded by a family whose domestic space is real agony.

PLAYER 3 (AS PROMPTER) *[reading the "book"].* "Leo Gala's house. A curious room serving as dining-room and study."

The Manager reduces all aesthetic decision to a single adjective; the brevity signals contempt for the material, not command of it.

THE MANAGER *[to **Property Man**].* Fix up the old red room.

She translates his laziness into logistics without comment — 'I'll turn them round' is a small comedy of institutional compromise.

PLAYER 2 (AS PROPERTY MAN) *[noting it down, not looking up].* Red set. *[A beat.]* Same flats as the blue room. I'll turn them round.

The stage direction read aloud foregrounds role-playing within role-playing; eggs being beaten introduce the theme of performed domesticity before the Characters arrive.

PLAYER 3 (AS PROMPTER) *[reading from the "book"]*. "When the curtain rises, Leo Gala, dressed in cook's cap and apron is busy beating an egg in a cup. Philip, also dressed as a cook, is beating another egg. Guido Venanzi is seated and listening."

Pre-emptive capitulation: the Manager knows the budget answer before asking, and 'Mime them' collapses art and economy into a single weary imperative.

THE MANAGER *[wearily, before anyone can object]*. Yes — real eggs, if the budget runs to it. *[It does not.]* Mime them.

The Leading Man's objection is not about comfort but about image — the cap threatens the persona he has spent fifteen years constructing.

PLAYER 1 (AS LEADING MAN) *[to Manager]*. Excuse me, but must I absolutely wear a cook's cap?

The Manager hides behind the text; 'it says so there' defers authority to the script rather than defending any aesthetic choice.

THE MANAGER *[annoyed]*. I imagine so. It says so there anyway. *[Pointing to the "book."]*

Vanity weaponised as tenure: the fifteen-year credential is offered to protect the ego, not to serve the play.

PLAYER 1 (AS LEADING MAN) *[a small grooming gesture — smoothing the hair before the line]*. But it's ridiculous. I have a reputation in this canton — fifteen years of it, sir, and not one inch built on a cook's cap.

The Property Man's flat irony punctures the Leading Man's self-importance without mercy — brevity as the sharpest contempt.

PLAYER 2 (AS PROPERTY MAN) *[not looking up from her clipboard]*. Fifteen years. And the cap is what finally finishes you.

The Manager's explosion is itself a performance: he channels existential frustration about the whole theatrical enterprise into an absurd lecture on symbolic eggs, losing and regaining control with practiced theatricality.

THE MANAGER *[jumping up in a rage]*. Ridiculous? Ridiculous? Is it my fault if France won't send us any more good comedies — Paris seems to be keeping them all for itself — and we are reduced to putting on Pirandello, whom nobody understands, including (I am beginning to suspect) Pirandello himself, who plays the fool with all of us and pockets the royalties from the comfort of the grave? *[The Actors grin. The Manager goes to Leading Man and shouts.]* Yes sir, you put on the cook's cap and beat eggs. Do you suppose that with all this egg-beating business you are on an ordinary stage? Get that out of your head. You represent the shell of the eggs you are beating! *[Laughter and comments among the Actors.]* Silence! and listen to my explanations, please! *[To Leading Man.]* "The empty form of reason without the fullness of instinct, which is blind." — You stand for reason, your wife is instinct. It's a mixing up of the parts, according to which you who act your own part become the puppet of yourself. Do you understand?

The resignation threat collapses the moment it leaves his mouth; both men know the hierarchy, and the beat of silence confirms it.

PLAYER 1 (AS LEADING MAN) *[the threat empty; both of them know it]*. I'd sooner resign. *[A beat. Nobody moves to stop him.]* I won't. But I'd sooner.

The Manager's candour — 'glorious failure' — is a defence mechanism, lowering expectations so catastrophe can be called a kind of success.

THE MANAGER. Wouldn't we all, sir. But let's get on with it. It's sure to be a glorious failure anyway — and a glorious failure is the closest thing this house has to a guarantee. *[Confidentially.]* But I say, please face three-quarters. Otherwise — what with the abstruseness of the dialogue, the public that won't be able to hear a word of it, and the critics who will hear far too much — the whole thing will go to hell. And I'll be blamed for all of it. Come on. Come on.

Wearing the cap 'under protest' is the Leading Man's last attempt to preserve dignity; the scaffold metaphor reveals how deeply the indignity registers.

PLAYER 1 (AS LEADING MAN) *[settling the cook's cap on his head with the dignity of a man mounting the scaffold]*. Let the record show that I wear it under protest.

The Prompter's domestic complaint — a draughty door, a first proper season — grounds the scene in the fragile aspirations of a working actor.

PLAYER 3 (AS PROMPTER). Pardon, sir — may I get into my box? There's a draught off that door they still haven't mended, and I'd rather not be hoarse for my first proper season.

The Manager's brisk assent barely registers the human request; the Prompter's comfort is administrative, not personal.

THE MANAGER. Yes, yes, of course!

*The white working lights soften into a warm amber — the "tenuous light" Pirandello specifies for the Six. The **Door-keeper** enters from the stage door carrying the **Boy-chair** — the black coat over its back, the cap on its seat, the satchel by its leg — sets it at the edge of the stage, and advances towards the Manager's table, taking off his braided cap. During this manoeuvre, the four live **Characters** — **Father**, **Mother**, **Step-Daughter**, **Son** — enter, and stop by the door at back of stage. The **Step-Daughter** is already carrying the **Child-bundle**.*

A tenuous light surrounds the Six, almost as if irradiated by them — the faint breath of their fantastic reality.

This tenuous light will disappear when they come forward towards the actors. They preserve, however, something of the dream lightness in which they seem almost suspended; but this does not detract from the essential reality of their forms and expressions.

*He who is known as **The Father** is a man of about 50: hair, reddish in colour, thin at the temples; he is not bald, however; thick moustaches, falling over his still fresh mouth, which often opens in an empty and uncertain smile. He is fattish, pale; with an especially wide forehead. He has blue, oval-shaped eyes, very clear and piercing. Wears light trousers and a dark jacket. He is alternatively mellifluous and violent in his manner.*

***The Mother** seems crushed and terrified as if by an intolerable weight of shame and abasement. She is dressed in modest black and wears a thick widow's veil of crêpe. When she lifts this, she reveals a wax-like face. She always keeps her eyes downcast.*

***The Step-Daughter** is dashing, almost impudent, beautiful. She wears mourning too, but with great elegance. She shows contempt for the wretched Boy-chair at the edge of the stage; she shows a lively tenderness for the Child-bundle in her arms.*

***The Son** (22) tall, severe in his attitude of contempt for **The Father**, supercilious and indifferent to **The Mother**. He looks as if he had come on the stage against his will.*

PART II — THE INTERRUPTION

The doorkeeper's apology performs deference while the actor beneath it cannot resist a tiny assertion of dignity — caught between two roles at once.

PLAYER 1 (AS DOOR-KEEPER) [*cap in hand — the Leading Man's diction still visible underneath*]. Excuse me, sir — *désolé* to interrupt; I know you don't like the morning's work disturbed...

The Manager's bark is reflex authority, an irritated refusal to shift attention; he hasn't looked up because nothing outside his rehearsal can matter yet.

THE MANAGER [*rudely*]. Eh? What is it?

The timid hedge and the lifted chin reveal the doorkeeper/actor's split loyalty: he followed orders and failed, and needs the Manager to know it wasn't his fault.

PLAYER 1 (AS DOOR-KEEPER) [*timidly — but not without a small lift of the chin*]. These people are asking for you, sir. I did tell them you were busy. They insisted.

The double address — scolding the door-keeper then pivoting to the strangers — shows the Manager asserting total territorial control over his rehearsal space.

THE MANAGER [*without looking up*]. I am rehearsing, and you know perfectly well no one's allowed to come in during rehearsals! [*Turning to the **Characters**.*] Who are you, please? What do you want?

The Father's hesitant 'actually' signals that the Characters already sense how absurd their need sounds; the ellipsis is an apology for what he cannot help asking.

THE FATHER [*coming forward a little, followed by the others who seem embarrassed*]. Actually... we have come here in search of an author...

The Manager's paired emotions — anger and amazement — reveal that the request has genuinely unsettled him; he repeats the word to make sure he heard it.

THE MANAGER *[half angry, half amazed]*. An author? What author?

The Father strips away all bargaining: he doesn't need a specific author, he needs the function of authorship — any witness who will hold their story.

THE FATHER. Any author, sir.

The Manager tries to close the door with practical logic, unaware he is also stating the Characters' deepest wound: there is no work, no form, for what they carry.

THE MANAGER. But there's no author here. We are not rehearsing a new piece.

The Step-Daughter hijacks the Father's opening move and turns it into a commercial pitch — simultaneously undercutting him and the theatre's self-importance.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[stepping in front of the Father, taking the line]*. So much the better, sir, so much the better. You can put us on tonight — we'll draw better than whatever you were rehearsing.

Player 3's exclamation is communal offence-taking; the actors bond in shared indignation to avoid sitting with the uncomfortable grain of truth in the taunt.

PLAYER 3 *[coming forward from the others]*. Oh — do you hear that?

The self-correction from 'perfectly' to 'adequately' is the whole wound: the Leading Man's vanity punctured in real time, in front of his company.

PLAYER 1 (AS LEADING MAN) *[stung; it lands because it is half true]*. We were drawing perfectly well. ...Adequately.

The Father reaches for the Manager through logic while simultaneously trying to restrain the Step-Daughter — two negotiations happening at once, both failing.

THE FATHER *[to Step-Daughter]*. Yes, but if the author isn't here... *[To Manager.]* unless you would be willing...

The Manager uses 'budget' alongside 'time' to demote the Characters' claim from existential to administrative — a bureaucrat's defense against the uncanny.

THE MANAGER. You are trying to be funny. We have neither the time nor the budget for funny.

The Father's 'for Heaven's sake' is genuine horror at being misread as comic; he needs the Manager to feel the weight before the argument can begin.

THE FATHER. No, for Heaven's sake, what are you saying? We bring you a drama, sir.

The Step-Daughter's offer is a dare wrapped in a promise; she knows their story is dangerous and bets that the Manager's theatrical greed will override his caution.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. We may be your fortune, sir — if you have the nerve for us.

The Manager bundles the Characters with 'our own' mad people — a dismissal that accidentally concedes a theatre is already full of controlled unreality.

THE MANAGER. Will you oblige me by going away? *Allez*, please. We haven't time to waste with mad people. We have our own.

The Father's softening voice is a rhetorical seduction: he narrows the distance physically and philosophically, preparing to make the Manager complicit in his worldview.

THE FATHER *[stepping closer, voice softening on each clause]*. Oh sir, you know well that life is full of infinite absurdities, which, strangely enough, do not even need to appear plausible, since they are true.

The Manager's bewilderment is genuine; the Father has shifted registers from petition to lecture, and the Manager hasn't consented to that shift.

THE MANAGER. What the devil is he talking about?

The Father pivots the insult of 'madness' back onto the theatre itself — flattering and accusing simultaneously, forcing the actors to consider what their craft actually does.

THE FATHER. I say that reversing the ordinary process may well seem like madness: that is, to create credible situations, so that they appear true. But let me point out that if this be madness, it is the sole *raison d'être* of your profession, gentlemen. *[The Actors look hurt and perplexed.]*

The Manager's question is defensive vanity: he heard the intellectual trap closing and chose the wrong escape, trading irritation for dignity-via-outrage.

THE MANAGER *[getting up and looking at him]*. So our profession seems to you one worthy of madmen then?

The Father restates the paradox as an honour, not an insult — but the compliment requires the actors to admit their art is a beautiful lie, which stings.

THE FATHER. Well — to make seem true that which isn't true. Isn't that your mission, gentlemen: to give life to fantastic characters on the stage?

The Manager's speech about 'immortal works' is the company's collective ego-rescue; the applause is self-soothing, a theatre defending itself against a mirror.

THE MANAGER *[interpreting the rising anger of the Company]*. But I beg you to believe, my dear sir, that the actor's profession is a noble one. If today's playwrights give us stupid comedies to play and puppets instead of real people, remember — we are proud to have given life to immortal works on these very boards. *[The Actors, satisfied, applaud their Manager.]*

The Father agrees so completely that it becomes an ambush: his embrace of the actors' claim reveals that fictional characters are more honest than the people in the room.

THE FATHER *[cutting across him]*. Exactly, perfectly. To living beings more alive than those who breathe and wear clothes — beings less real, perhaps, but truer. Truer because they cannot lie about themselves the way we can. I agree with you entirely. *[The Actors look at one another in amazement.]*

The Step-Daughter's aside is a knife slipped between the Father's ribs: she collapses his grand philosophy into the personal history she alone witnessed.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[quiet, just to the room]*. Truer. He has been using that word for years. Ask my mother how true it sounded.

The Manager's confusion signals that the Father has moved faster than the conversation can follow — a philosopher outpacing the room while the room still thinks it's in charge.

THE MANAGER. But what do you mean? Before, you said...

The Father reframes the Manager's own impatience as proof of the Father's point — turning the Manager's words against him to demonstrate the creative instinct the Manager claims to serve.

THE FATHER. No, excuse me, I meant it for you, sir, who were crying out that you had no time to lose with madmen, while no one better than yourself knows that nature uses the instrument of human fantasy to pursue her high creative purpose.

The Manager's pragmatic question is a small surrender — he has stopped trying to evict them and is now, despite himself, following the argument.

THE MANAGER. Very well, — but where does all this take us?

The Father's catalogue of natural forms positions the Characters as inevitable products of creation's logic, not intruders — being born a character is as unchosen as being born human.

THE FATHER. Nowhere! It is merely to show you that one is born to life in many forms, in many shapes, as tree, or as stone, as water, as butterfly, or as woman. So one may also be born a character in a play.

The Manager's 'feigned' dismay is the first crack of genuine engagement disguised as comedy; he is beginning to play with the idea even as he mocks it.

THE MANAGER *[with feigned comic dismay]*. So you and these other friends of yours have been born characters?

The Father's 'Exactly!' is triumphant but premature — the laughter that follows shows he has won the argument in his own head while losing the room.

THE FATHER. Exactly, and alive as you see! [*Manager and Actors burst out laughing.*]

The Father's hurt is strategic as much as genuine: he deploys the Mother's silent grief as visual evidence, redirecting attention from the absurdity to the pathos.

THE FATHER [*hurt*]. I am sorry you laugh, because we carry in us a drama, as you can guess from this woman here veiled in black.

The Manager's explosion marks the exact moment he decides argument is futile — but ordering them out is also an admission that he cannot simply ignore them.

THE MANAGER [*losing patience at last and almost indignant*]. Oh, enough! Out, please! Clear out of here! [*To Property Man.*] For Heaven's sake, turn them out!

The Father's resistance is almost physical; his repeated 'no, no' signals that for the Characters, expulsion is not an inconvenience but an existential threat.

THE FATHER [*resisting*]. No, no, look here, we...

The Manager's roar is the sound of a man who realizes shouting is all he has left — the rational argument has escaped him and only volume remains.

THE MANAGER [*roaring*]. We come here to work, you know.

The Leading Man's joke about lunch is a class marker and a shield: he retreats into witty self-regard rather than admit the Characters have genuinely unsettled him.

PLAYER 1 (AS LEADING MAN). One cannot allow oneself to be made a fool of, not before lunch, anyway.

The Father draws the actors' own professional experience as his evidence — if they can inhabit fictional lives, why can't fictional lives seek bodies to inhabit?

THE FATHER [*determined, coming forward*]. Your disbelief amazes me, gentlemen. Aren't you used to seeing the characters created by an author spring to life in yourselves and face each other? Just because there is no "book" [*Pointing to the Prompter's box.*] which contains us, you refuse to believe...

The Step-Daughter's 'side-tracked' is the calmest and most devastating word in the scene — it names abandonment as administrative failure, stripping away all sentiment.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER [*advances towards Manager, eyes level, not smiling*]. Believe me, we are really six most interesting characters, sir; side-tracked however.

The Father's literary roll call — Sancho Panza, Madame Bovary — is both his most elegant argument and an act of envy: those characters were finished; his family was not.

THE FATHER. Yes, that is the word! [*To Manager.*] The author who created us alive no longer wished, or was no longer able, to put us into a work of art. That was a real crime, sir. He who is born a character can laugh even at death. The writer dies; the creation does not — and it needs no extraordinary gift to live forever. Who was Sancho Panza? Who was Madame Bovary? They live eternally, because they found a fantasy that could nourish them. We had no such fortune.

The Step-Daughter's 'many times' tells us the Father's grief for their abandonment has become a performance rehearsed for strangers — she has been his unwilling audience.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER [*low, to no one in particular*]. He has said all this to himself before. Many times.

The Manager's 'quite all right' is exhausted concession masquerading as politeness; he has stopped fighting the philosophy and now just wants a practical answer.

THE MANAGER. That is quite all right. But what do you want here, all of you?

Three words that compress the Characters' entire ontological need into something pre-rational — not to tell their story, not to be remembered, simply to exist.

THE FATHER. We want to live.

The Manager's 'For Eternity?' is a flash of sardonic comedy that also marks his first moment of genuine imaginative engagement — the absurdity has caught him.

THE MANAGER. For Eternity?

The Father's 'only for a moment... in you' is the most intimate request in the play: not an audience but an incarnation, asking the actors to become vessels.

THE FATHER. No, sir, only for a moment... in you.

Player 3's 'honestly' is the honest reaction: the theatre person's mixture of contempt and half-fascination that they cannot yet bring themselves to admit as the latter.

PLAYER 3. Just listen to him. Honestly — just listen.

The Leading Lady's sotto voce cruelty — 'as if there were room' — reveals professional jealousy dressed as metaphysics; she is protecting her status, not making a philosophical point.

PLAYER 2 (AS LEADING LADY) [*chin up, the diva back; sotto voce to Player 1*]. They want to live, in us... as if there were room.

The Leading Man's preening confidence is entirely about the Step-Daughter; 'I have room' is vanity posturing as generosity, telegraphing his attraction.

PLAYER 1 (AS LEADING MAN) [*smoothing a sleeve*]. Speak for yourself. I have room.

Player 3's pointing singles out the Step-Daughter as a body to be desired and embodied — reducing her existential plea to an audition for his attention.

PLAYER 3 (AS JUVENILE LEAD) [*pointing to the **Step-Daughter***]. I've no objection, as far as that one is concerned!

The Father's 'Look here!' signals he is losing control of the room and pivots to the Manager as his last practical authority — desperation dressed as organisational energy.

THE FATHER. Look here! look here! The comedy has to be made. [*To the **Manager**.*] But if you and your actors are willing, we can soon concert it among ourselves.

The Manager's list of genres ends with self-deprecating honesty about the revue, showing he is capable of irony — a brief human moment before he retreats to gatekeeping.

THE MANAGER [*annoyed*]. But what do you want to concert? We don't go in for concerts here. Here we play dramas, comedies, and — once a year, against my better judgment — a musical revue. Not whatever this is.

The Father's 'Exactly!' is structurally identical to line 48: he seizes any opening as confirmation, turning the Manager's dismissal into an invitation.

THE FATHER. Exactly! That is just why we have come to you.

The Manager demands a 'book' because a book is something he can control — he cannot stage what has no material form, and the request exposes his medium's limits.

THE MANAGER. And where is the "book"?

The Father's insistence that the drama is in them asks the actors to trust the living body over the written text — which is precisely what actors dread and desire.

THE FATHER. It is in us! [*The **Actors** laugh.*] The drama is in us, and we are the drama. We are impatient to play it. Our inner passion drives us on to this.

The Step-Daughter's aside strips the Father's communal 'our' down to 'his': she does not share his passion, she is its object and its casualty.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER [*without looking at him*]. His passion. Always the word *passion*.

The hand on the Father's shoulder — held one beat too long — is a public staging of the private act that shames them both; she weaponises the touch she cannot take back.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER [*crossing behind the Father, voice flat*]. My passion, sir. Ah, if you only knew — my passion for *him*. [*Places a deliberate hand on the **Father's** shoulder, leaves it there one beat too long, withdraws. A single short laugh — no warmth in it.*]

The Father's anger at her laugh is not moral outrage but fear of exposure: her cold amusement dismantles the philosophical dignity he has been constructing.

THE FATHER *[angrily]*. Behave yourself! And please don't laugh in that fashion.

The Step-Daughter's performance is a controlled detonation — she announces her orphan status and then immediately punctures its pathos with cabaret, refusing pity.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. With your permission, gentlemen, I, who am a two months' orphan, will show you how well I can dance and sing. *Don't worry — it isn't a hymn. [Sings and then dances Prenez garde à Tchou-Tchin-Tchou.]*

The Players' encore call is the theatre's reflex to spectacle; they have forgotten, for a moment, that they were contemptuous — entertainment has overridden judgment.

ALL THREE PLAYERS. Bravo! Well done! Encore!

The Manager's alarm at her sanity is really alarm at his own response: he wants to restore order precisely because the song nearly worked on him.

THE MANAGER. Silence! This isn't a café concert, you know! *[Turning to the **Father** in consternation.]* Is she mad?

A professional actor conceding reluctant admiration to a real person, his theatrical metrics briefly eclipsed by something he cannot name.

PLAYER 1 (AS LEADING MAN) *[to Player 2, won over]*. She has more stage presence than the second act. I'll say that.

The Father refuses the comfortable category of madness; to call her mad would neutralise her, and he knows she is something more dangerous — right.

THE FATHER. Mad? No, she's worse than mad.

The Step-Daughter seizes directorial authority, mapping the entire plot in advance to strip the Father of any narrative control he might claim.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[to Manager]*. Worse? Listen! Stage this drama now, sir! At a certain moment, when we lose this little darling, and this fool here *[Seizing the coat off the chair and shaking it.]* does the stupidest thing — you will see me run away. Yes, gentlemen, I'll be off. But the moment hasn't come yet. After what has taken place between him and me *[Indicating the Father with a horrible wink.]*, I can't stay here, watching her anguish over that fool *[Indicates the Son.]*. Look at him — frigid, indifferent, because he is the *legitimate* son. He despises us all because we are bastards. *[Goes to the Mother and embraces her.]* And he won't even recognise her as his mother. *Wretch.*

The Mother's bodily collapse is the only language available to her; physical breakdown becomes the most eloquent speech she has yet made.

THE MOTHER *[to the **Manager**; one arm tightens around the Child-bundle, the other goes toward the Boy-chair as if to keep both of them upright]*. In the name of these two little children, I beg you... *[She grows faint and is about to fall.]* Oh God!

The Father's chivalry is performance — he moves to help while simultaneously positioning himself as the scene's moral centre before the company.

THE FATHER *[coming forward to support her as do some of the **Actors**]*. Quick, a chair, a chair for this poor widow!

The Actors' collective doubt reveals their instinct to classify everything as theatre; they cannot yet accept that this suffering is not a rehearsal.

ALL THREE PLAYERS. Is it true? Has she really fainted?

The Manager organises practical help but his real impulse is to stage the crisis; the chair is also a prop in the scene he is already directing.

THE MANAGER. Quick, a chair! Here! *[One of the **Actors** brings a chair, the **Others** proffer assistance. The **Mother** tries to prevent the **Father** from lifting the veil which covers her face.]*

The Father's command is an act of aggression disguised as exhibition — forcing the Mother's pain into public view serves his need to be witnessed as victim.

THE FATHER. Look at her! Look at her!

The Mother's resistance is not modesty but self-preservation; the veil is the last boundary between her private wound and the spectacle the Father wants.

THE MOTHER. No, no; stop it please!

Lifting the veil is violation framed as disclosure; the Father appropriates her body to make his argument, as he has done throughout the marriage.

THE FATHER *[raising her veil]*. Let them see you!

She appeals to the Manager to stop the Father, naming what she cannot bear: being made into evidence in someone else's case.

THE MOTHER *[rising and covering her face with her hands]*. I beg you, sir. Stop him. I cannot bear what he wants to do.

The Manager reaches for the familiar category of domestic melodrama, hoping a simple label will restore his authority over the material.

THE MANAGER *[dumbfounded]*. I don't understand at all. What is the situation? Is this lady your wife? *[To the **Father**.]*

The Father's flat confirmation carries a possessive pride that exposes the contradiction: he still claims her while having driven her away.

THE FATHER. Yes, gentlemen: my wife!

The Actors' laugh is a defence mechanism; they grasp the logical absurdity to avoid confronting the emotional reality underneath it.

THE MANAGER. But how can she be a widow if you are alive? *[The **Actors** find relief for their astonishment in a loud laugh.]*

The Father's urgency to silence the laughter is self-interest — he needs the room solemn so his reframing of the story can take hold.

THE FATHER. Don't laugh! Don't laugh like that, for Heaven's sake. Her drama lies just here in this: she has had a lover, a man who should be here.

The Mother's involuntary cry escapes before she can suppress it; her hand against her mouth shows she has spent years training herself into silence.

THE MOTHER *[the cry surprising her — a hand goes to her own mouth, as if to catch it]*. No! No!

The Step-Daughter weaponises mourning etiquette, her ironic 'most respectable' exposing how social form papers over catastrophe.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Fortunately for her, sir, he is dead. Two months ago, as I said. We are in mourning, as you see. Most respectable.

The Father reclassifies the Mother as non-person — 'not a woman, a mother' — erasing her desire so that only his philosophical narrative remains.

THE FATHER. He isn't here, you see, not because he is dead. He isn't here because her drama is not a drama of love at all. She felt nothing for either of us — perhaps a little gratitude, not for me, for the other. She isn't a woman, she is a mother. And her drama — powerful sir, I assure you — lies all in these four children she has had by two men.

*At the word children, the **Mother's** arm closes around the Child-bundle, before any word comes.*

The Mother's eruption breaks her habitual silence; the shift from passive to active grammar ('he gave me') is the first time she claims the story.

THE MOTHER. I had them? Have you got the courage to say that I *wanted* them? *[To the **Company**.]* It was him. He gave me to that other man. He made me go.

The Step-Daughter's blunt denial is a reflex of loyalty to the Father's rival, not an argument; she fights a different battle than the Mother.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. It isn't true.

The Mother echoes the Step-Daughter's words back as a question, feeling the denial land on her body before she can formulate a rebuttal.

THE MOTHER *[her hand tightens on the Child-bundle without her noticing]*. Not true, isn't it?

The Step-Daughter's triple repetition is not emphasis but anxiety — she is convincing herself as much as the room.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. No, it isn't true, it just isn't true.

The Mother's question is not rhetorical; it is genuine anguish that a daughter who was not yet born claims to know what the mother lived.

THE MOTHER. And what can you know about it?

The Step-Daughter reveals that her defence of the Father is really self-defence: if the Father is absolved, the Son's indifference to the Mother is inexcusable and the family wound stays open.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. It isn't true. Don't believe it. *[To **Manager**.]* Do you know why she says so? For that fellow there. *[Indicates the **Son**.]* She tortures herself, destroys herself on account of the neglect of that son there; and she wants him to believe that if she abandoned him when he was only two years old, it was because he *[Indicates the **Father**.]* made her do so.

The Mother's first upward glance — toward the Son who does not return it — and its immediate retreat is the entire drama of her maternal failure distilled into a stage direction.

THE MOTHER *[voice tight; eyes still on the floor].* He forced me to it. *[Silence. No one fills it. For the first time she raises her eyes — to the **Son**. He does not look back. She lowers them again.]* And I call God to witness it. *[To the **Manager**, still without lifting her head.]* Ask him *[Indicates the **Father**.]* if it isn't true. Let him speak. You *[To the **Step-Daughter**.]* are not in a position to know anything about it.

The Step-Daughter invokes the dead father's tenderness as a weapon, using happiness as evidence against the Mother's claim of coercion.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. I know you lived in peace and happiness with my father while he lived. Can you deny it?

The Mother's incomplete denial is a confession of complexity; she cannot lie about the happiness, and that honesty costs her the argument.

THE MOTHER. No, I don't deny it...

The Step-Daughter shakes the empty coat as if the dead man could still testify; her violence toward the prop betrays grief beneath the attack.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. He was always full of affection and kindness for you. *[Turning on the Boy-chair, gripping the lapel of the coat as if shaking him by it.]* It's true, isn't it? Tell them! Why don't you speak, you little fool?

The Mother's refusal to offend the dead man shows her wound is still loyal; she distinguishes between the act of leaving and the passion that might excuse it.

THE MOTHER. Leave him alone. Why do you want to make me appear ungrateful, daughter? I don't want to offend your father. I have told him: I did not leave my house and my son through any fault of mine. Not from any wilful passion.

The Father's rare, flat admission is more damning than any speech; brevity strips away the philosophical scaffolding and leaves only the act.

THE FATHER. It's true. It was my doing.

The Leading Man's unfinished sentence marks the moment real pain crosses into the theatre space and his appetite for spectacle curdles into discomfort.

PLAYER 1 (AS LEADING MAN) *[to the **Company**, beginning to relish it — then his eyes reach the **Mother**, and the end of the sentence does not arrive].* What a spectacle. What an absolute... *[He stops. The treat has gone out of it.]*

The Leading Lady's quiet observation signals the company's collective demotion — the professionals have become the audience for something they cannot perform.

PLAYER 2 (AS LEADING LADY) *[lower now].* We are the audience this time.

Player 3's single phrase, met with silence, registers that the normal social release of laughter has been shut down by the weight of what they are watching.

PLAYER 3 *[quietly, the pencil not moving].* For once. *[Nobody laughs.]*

The Manager's lean forward is the tell — he has stopped directing and started listening; the sceptic is becoming a witness despite himself.

THE MANAGER *[beginning to get really interested — leaning slightly forward, the way an audience member does when they have started to listen].* Let's hear them out. Listen!

The Son pre-empt's the Father with contemptuous labelling, hoping that ridicule will neutralise the philosophical seduction before it works on the room.

THE SON. Oh yes, you're going to hear a fine bit now. He will talk to you of the Demon of Experiment.

The Father's self-awareness that he 'found an expression to excuse myself' is the most honest thing he says, and he buries it immediately in attack.

THE FATHER. You are a cynical imbecile. I've told you so already a hundred times. *[To the **Manager**.]* He tries to make fun of me on account of this expression which I have found to excuse myself with.

The Son's monotone repetition performs the very thing it criticises — he too uses a word as a wall to keep the Father's pain at arm's length.

THE SON *[without looking up]*. Yes. Phrases. Phrases.

The Father's appeal to universal human frailty is also a strategic move: if everyone hides behind words, no one is singularly guilty.

THE FATHER. Phrases! Isn't everyone consoled when faced with a trouble or fact he doesn't understand, by a word, some simple word, which tells us nothing and yet calms us?

The Step-Daughter cuts through the Father's philosophy with surgical precision; she names remorse as the most self-serving word of all.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Even remorse. Especially remorse.

The Father's insistence that he acted beyond words is a setup for the revelation of the hundred francs — the action he substituted for feeling.

THE FATHER. Remorse? No, that isn't true. I've done more than use words to quieten the remorse in me.

The hundred francs makes the abstraction concrete and sordid; the Step-Daughter times the detail to destroy whatever sympathy the Father has built.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Yes, there was money. A nice little bit. The hundred francs he was about to lay down for me, gentlemen — and I two months an orphan. *[A ripple of unease among the **Actors**.]*

The Son's disgust at the Step-Daughter's exposure is also shame — her vile act of telling mirrors his own refusal to confront the family's reality.

THE SON *[to the **Step-Daughter**]*. This is vile.

The Step-Daughter catalogues Madame Pace's shop with forensic precision, forcing the polite euphemism 'robes et manteaux' to carry its real cargo of exploitation.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Vile? There they were in a pale blue envelope on a little mahogany table in the back of Madame Pace's shop. You know Madame Pace, sir — one of those *ladies* who take in poor girls of good family on the pretext of selling *robes et manteaux*. The pretext is always *robes*. The arrangement is always something else.

*As the shop is named, the **Mother** draws the Child-bundle up against her and covers its ears with her hand.*

The Son turns the unpaid money into a moral paradox: the Father is guilty of the intent even though the act was interrupted — money as proof of desire.

THE SON. And he thinks he bought the right to tyrannize over us with that hundred francs. Which — note this, gentlemen — he never got the chance to pay.

The Step-Daughter's ironic laugh compresses bitterness, survivor relief, and self-contempt into a single sound that has nowhere respectable to go.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. It was a near thing, though, you know! *[Laughs ironically.]*

The Mother shields the Child before she speaks; her words are directed inward, a mother's reflex to protect innocence from the shame already filling the room.

THE MOTHER *[low, not raised; she turns the Child-bundle's face into her shoulder before she speaks — the words are for the bundle, not the room]*. Shame, my daughter. *[A breath. The **Step-Daughter's** laugh is still in the air.]* Not in front of her.

The Step-Daughter claims ownership of the shame and inverts it into power, describing the scene with such precision that memory becomes a kind of re-enactment the Father cannot stop.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Shame? Oh, the shame is mine — and the *revenge*. I am dying to live that scene. The room — I see it. Here is the window with the mantles in display, there the divan, the looking-glass, a screen, and in front of the window the little mahogany table with the blue envelope and its hundred francs. I see it. I can almost take hold of it. But you, gentlemen, might look elsewhere for this part of it. I do not blush, however. *He* does. *[Indicating **Father**.]*

The Manager's confusion is also the audience's; Pirandello plants him here as a surrogate for any viewer overwhelmed by the collapsing frames.

THE MANAGER *[the audience's confusion, on stage]*. I don't understand this at all.

The Father's composure is visibly effortful — sweating, recovering — and the recovery itself is the betrayal; guilt shows not in the fall but in the repair.

THE FATHER *[he is sweating, very slightly, and trying to keep it from being read; the recovery is visible, that is the trouble].* Of course. — Sir. Before you decide what she has just put on me, you must let me explain.

The Step-Daughter grants permission with contempt baked in; she already knows exactly what his explanation will do and what it will leave out.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Ah yes, explain it in your own way.

The Father generalises his personal failure into a universal epistemological tragedy, transforming his specific guilt into everyone's shared condition.

THE FATHER. But don't you see that the whole trouble lies here. In words. Words. Each one of us has inside him a whole world of things — his own world. Some of those things are unspeakable. So we speak around them. And how can we ever understand each other, if I mean one thing by my words and you hear another? We think we understand. We never really do.

Player 3's dry aside punctures the Father's rhetoric from outside the emotional field; the joke survives precisely because it refuses to be moved.

PLAYER 3 *[a whisper to Player 1].* I understood words. I'm fairly confident about words.

The Mother's three words carry more weight than all the Father's speeches; the simplest statement is the one that has waited longest to be said.

THE MOTHER. But you drove me away.

The Father's disbelief is performance — he needs witnesses to hear him deny responsibility more than he needs the Mother to understand him.

THE FATHER. Do you hear her? I drove her away! She believes I really sent her away.

The Mother's self-erasure — 'a poor woman, nothing' — is the root injury: she was married into disappearance long before she was sent away.

THE MOTHER *[looking at the floor between them].* You know how to talk, and I don't. But believe me, sir *[To Manager.]* — after he had married me... who knows why?... I was a poor woman. Nothing.

The Father's spread arms are the gesture of a man who has always considered himself misunderstood, but the silence that follows shows no one is rushing to prove him right.

THE FATHER. — it was for your humility that I married you. I loved this simplicity in you. *[He stops when he sees she makes signs to contradict him, opens his arms wide — the gesture of a man who has, for twenty years, been unable to be heard inside his own house.]* You see — she denies it. She cannot hear me. *[Touches his forehead. A short silence; nobody comes to his aid.]* She has never been able to hear me. She has a heart for the children. When I speak — nothing.

The Step-Daughter redirects the inquiry away from the Father's feelings toward concrete consequence — intelligence measured by its damage, not its depth.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Yes, but ask him how his intelligence has helped us.

The Father's rhetorical question is a last philosophical escape hatch, but the stage direction that immediately follows — vanity breaking into the room — punctures it.

THE FATHER. If we could see all the evil that can come from good, what would we do? *[At this point the **Leading Lady** who is biting her lips with rage at seeing the **Leading Man** flirting with the **Step-Daughter**, comes forward and says to the **Manager**.]*

The Leading Lady's impatience is a professional's defense: she mocks the intrusion to re-assert the theatre's authority over reality.

PLAYER 2 (AS LEADING LADY). Excuse me — *mais sérieusement* — are we going to rehearse today, or have we converted to a lecture series?

The Manager stalls, caught between his practical duty and a growing, unwilling fascination he cannot yet admit.

THE MANAGER. Of course, of course; but let's hear them out.

The Ingénue's faint praise — 'educational' — is a polite weapon, distancing the Characters as specimens rather than rivals for stage time.

PLAYER 1 (AS L'INGÉNUÉ) *[the falsetto is half a beat too low; the Leading Man's voice is showing].* Most interesting. In a kind of educational way.

Class resentment surfaces: the Leading Lady aligns herself with labour against philosophy, and the glance at Leading Man is a bid for solidarity.

PLAYER 2 (AS LEADING LADY). Yes — for the kind of audience that goes in for that kind of evening. The rest of us are working actors. We have rent to pay. *[Casts a glance at **Leading Man**.]*

The Manager's command to the Father is a director's move — seating himself signals he has accepted, provisionally, the role of audience.

THE MANAGER *[to **Father**]*. You must please explain yourself quite clearly. *[Sits down.]*

The Father's measured sympathy for the clerk is self-serving groundwork: framing himself as generous patron before disclosing he engineered the arrangement.

THE FATHER. Very well then: listen! I had in my service a poor man, a clerk, a secretary of mine, full of devotion, who became friends with her. *[Indicating the **Mother**.]* They understood each other, kindred souls in fact, without the slightest suspicion of evil between them. They were incapable even of thinking of it.

The Step-Daughter's interjection punctures the Father's philanthropy in four words, naming the desire he is wrapping in euphemism.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. So he thought of it — for them!

The Father's 'constant rage' at silent glances reveals a man who cannot tolerate intimacy that excludes him — control disguised as suffering.

THE FATHER. That's not true. I meant to do good to them — and to myself, I confess, at the same time. Things had reached the point where I couldn't say a word to either of them without their making a silent appeal to each other with their eyes. I could see them silently asking each other how to keep me calm, how to keep me quiet. And this alone, believe me, was enough to keep me in a constant rage — to exasperate me beyond measure.

The Manager's question is the obvious one, and its obviousness is the trap: the Father has been waiting for it to justify the next revelation.

THE MANAGER. And why didn't you send him away then — this secretary of yours?

The Father's animal simile exposes his contempt even as he claims pity; he pictures the Mother as a pet, not a person.

THE FATHER. Precisely what I did, sir. And then I had to watch this poor woman wandering the house like an animal without a master. Like an animal one has taken in out of pity.

The Mother's sigh is not agreement — it is the sound of someone enduring a version of her own story that is not hers.

THE MOTHER. Ah yes...

The Father turns to the Mother for corroboration, weaponising her silence and putting her in the impossible position of witness against herself.

THE FATHER *[suddenly turning to the **Mother**]*. It's true about the son anyway, isn't it?

The Mother corrects the sequence: the son was taken first, making every subsequent act of 'liberation' read as compounded dispossession.

THE MOTHER. He took my son away from me first of all.

The Father's claim of country air and health is a middle-class rationalisation that names the child's benefit while burying the Mother's loss.

THE FATHER. But not from cruelty. I did it so that he should grow up healthy and strong by living in the country.

The Step-Daughter's two words and a pointing finger demolish the Father's rationale — the Son's visible coldness is the evidence against him.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[pointing at him, no smile]*. As one can see.

The Father's cascade of self-exculpation — wet nurse, weak mother, moral aspirations — reveals a man who can only confess in the same breath as an excuse.

THE FATHER *[quickly]*. Is it my fault if he has grown up like this? I sent him to a wet nurse in the country, a peasant, as his mother did not seem strong enough. That, sir, was the reason I married her. Unpleasant — but how can it be helped? All my life I have had these damned aspirations toward a moral sanity I never quite reach.

The Manager's exasperation is comic but also a stage director's instinct: story, not philosophy, is what the theatre can use.

THE MANAGER. Yes, please stop it, for Heaven's sake.

The Step-Daughter's 'regular customer' lands as a court verdict: she converts abstract moral aspiration into a transaction with a price and an address.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. But imagine moral sanity from *him*, if you please — a regular customer of Madame Pace's shop. A very regular customer.

Player 1's discomfort is the company's conscience speaking: the theatre professional senses he has wandered into something that cannot be rehearsed away.

PLAYER 1 *[shifting in his seat, looking elsewhere]*. — These are not the lines of a play I auditioned for.

The Father's 'Fool!' is self-directed anger redirected outward; the speech that follows is his most elaborate attempt to make contradiction into virtue.

THE FATHER *[a hand goes to his brow, almost despite himself]*. Fool! That is the proof that I am a man. This seeming contradiction, gentlemen, is the strongest proof that I stand here a *live* man before you. It is precisely this incongruity in my nature that has made me suffer what I have suffered. I couldn't live beside that woman *[Indicating the Mother.]* any longer; not so much for the boredom she inspired in me, as for the pity I felt for her.

The Step-Daughter's flat repetition of 'He calls it pity' is deliberate deadpan: she lets the word echo until it rots in the air.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[flat, into the room]*. He calls it pity. He was caught buying his stepdaughter in the back of a dressmaker's shop. He calls it *pity*.

The Mother's incomplete sentence — the dash — is the hinge; she cannot finish because the act of being turned out still has no proper name for her.

THE MOTHER. And so he turned me out —.

The Father's 'well provided for' is a bookkeeper's phrase hiding a transaction: he paid her off and calls the currency freedom.

THE FATHER. — well provided for! Yes, I sent her to that man, gentlemen... to let her go free of me.

The Mother's three-word rejoinder strips the Father's altruism to its skeleton — the liberation was always primarily his.

THE MOTHER. And to free himself.

The Father's long speech about watching from a distance reframes surveillance as tenderness; the crossed arms betray the self-consciousness of a man composing himself mid-lie.

THE FATHER. Yes. I admit it. It was a liberation, also, for me. *[Beat.]* But great evil has come of it. I meant well, sir. I did it for her sake more than for mine — I have never once doubted it. *[Crosses his arms; then turns to the Mother.]* Did I ever lose sight of you, until that other man carried you off to another town? Out of pure interest in you, with no base motive in it, I watched — from a long way off — the new family that grew up around her. *[Points to the Step-Daughter.]*

The Step-Daughter's childhood memory is delivered to the room, not to the Father — she makes the audience the jury, not him.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Oh yes, that's true enough. When I was little, so high, you know, with plaits over my shoulders and my skirt down past my knees, I used to see him waiting outside the school for me to come out. He came, sir, to see how I was *growing up*.

The Father's outcry is shame performing outrage; 'infamous' is the word of a man afraid the image is true rather than certain it is false.

THE FATHER. This is infamous, shameful!

The Step-Daughter's quiet 'Why?' is the cruelest possible response — she refuses him even the dignity of a denial to push against.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. No. Why?

The Father's 'dazed fly' and the account of the Son's estrangement reveal that his surveillance of the Step-Daughter's family was filling a vacuum he was responsible for creating.

THE FATHER. Infamous! infamous! After she *[Indicating the Mother.]* went away, my house seemed suddenly empty. She had been my nightmare, but she filled my house. I was like a dazed fly alone in the empty rooms. This boy here *[Indicating the Son.]* was educated away from home; when he came back, he seemed to me to be no more mine. With no mother between him and me, he grew up apart, on his own, with no tie of intellect or affection. And then — strange but true — I was driven, by curiosity at first and then by some tender sentiment, toward her family, which had come into being through my will. The thought of her began gradually to fill the emptiness I felt all around me.

Player 2's mock-scholarly gesture is the company losing its ironic distance; even the cynics are being drawn in against their professional will.

PLAYER 2 *[the back of a script suddenly being used as a notepad]*. Should we be writing this down? Some of it sounds important.

The Step-Daughter recounts the hat and flowers without horror — the forensic calm is more damning than outrage, each detail a piece of evidence she has long catalogued.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Yes, yes. True. He used to follow me in the street and smile at me, wave his hand like this. I looked at him, doubtful, wondering who he might be. I told my mother, who guessed at once. *[The Mother agrees with a nod.]* Then she wouldn't send me to school for some days. When I went back, there he was again — looking so ridiculous — with a paper parcel: a fine straw hat, a bouquet of flowers, all for me.

The Manager's 'discursive' is a dramaturg's complaint: the story is real but shapeless, and the theatre needs a scene, not a deposition.

THE MANAGER. A bit discursive this, you know!

The Son's repeated 'Literature' is contempt for the Father's self-dramatisation and for the whole theatrical frame that flatters everyone's pain into story.

THE SON *[turning his face away from the Father]*. Literature. Literature.

The Father's retort — life, passion — exposes his deepest vanity: he believes his suffering is too real for mere fiction, even as he performs it.

THE FATHER. Literature indeed! This is life, this is passion!

The Manager's 'it won't act' is the theatre's verdict on reality: experience that cannot be shaped for an audience has no place on his stage.

THE MANAGER. It may be, but it won't act.

The Father pre-emptively edits his own story for stagability, revealing he has already thought about which parts to suppress — the stalking, the gifts.

THE FATHER. I agree. This is only the part leading up. I don't suggest this should be staged. She *[Pointing to the Step-Daughter.]*, as you see, is no longer the schoolgirl with plaits down her back —.

The Step-Daughter's completion of the Father's sentence is an act of possession — she will not let him control even the grammar of her own transformation.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. — and the skirt down past the knee!

The Father's relish for 'complex, most interesting' is a connoisseur's excitement about his own catastrophe — guilt aestheticised into a selling point.

THE FATHER. The drama is coming now, sir; something new, complex, most interesting.

The Step-Daughter begins with the father's death as fact, not grief — the biological father's absence is simply the door through which disaster entered.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. As soon as my father died...

The Father's small pointing gesture 'immediately regretted' shows his habit of using the Mother as exhibit, then catching himself too late.

THE FATHER. — there was absolute misery for them. They came back here, without my knowing. *[A small pointing gesture toward the Mother, immediately regretted.]* She can barely write her own name; but she could at least have had her daughter write — to tell me that they were in need.

The Mother's question is not rhetorical — it is the genuine bewilderment of a woman for whom his 'sentiment' was always invisible behind his actions.

THE MOTHER. And how was I to divine all this sentiment in him?

The Father turns the Mother's incomprehension into her failure, as if emotional literacy were a duty she breached rather than a code he kept secret.

THE FATHER. That is exactly your mistake, never to have guessed any of my sentiments.

The Mother's unfinished sentence holds the entire weight of the years he is glossing over — time and event are her evidence, not his feeling.

THE MOTHER. After so many years apart, and all that had happened...

The word 'naturally' arrives before the Father can stop it and does more damage than the rest of the speech: it confesses that his interest was conditional, always.

THE FATHER. Was it my fault if that fellow carried you away? After he had found some job, I could find no trace of them — and, *[the word arrives before he can stop it]* naturally, my interest dwindled. *[The room hears the word "naturally". He does not look up.]* But the drama culminated, unforeseen, on their return — when I was driven by the loneliness that still had its grip on me. Ah, what wretchedness is in the man who is alone, and too proud for the shabby, easy comforts. Not old enough to do without company. Not young enough to seek it without shame. It is worse than misery. Every man carries things in the secrecy of his own heart that he would never say aloud. *[A beat. He has to swallow.]* One gives way to a moment's weakness, and then rises from it, and is himself again — and the moment is not the man. Most men simply haven't the courage to admit the moment was ever there at all. That is the only difference between us. That's all.

Player 1's whispered rudeness is the company's id speaking — the speech has stripped decorum and what remains is the audience's private, unspeakable reaction.

PLAYER 1 *[under his breath, to Player 3].* I have several questions. None of them are polite.

The Step-Daughter's nine words answer the Father's whole theory of secret shame: the courage he claims is not courage but impunity dressed as honesty.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. All appear to have the courage to do them though.

The Father's theory of mutual blindness is a sophisticated absolution factory — he turns social hypocrisy into a system that makes him merely its most honest member.

THE FATHER. Yes, but in secret. Let a man only speak them out, and folks at once label him a cynic. But he is like all the others — he only admits, with the light of intelligence, the plain shame in all of us that most men prefer to close their eyes upon. Two people drift toward a thing neither will name; the moment they are caught at it, they both look away. It is the way we tell each other: *blind yourself, because I have.*

The Step-Daughter's speech is the philosophical counter-attack: she names what his system cannot accommodate — the woman who no longer needs to look away, who sees clearly and is disgusted.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Sometimes one of the two cannot look away any more — when she no longer feels the need of hiding her shame from herself, but dry-eyed and dispassionately sees only the shame of the man who has blinded himself without love. Oh, all this philosophy that uncovers the worst in a man and then seeks to excuse him — I can't stand it, sir. When a man simplifies life down to appetite, throwing aside every finer aspiration, every sense of duty, modesty, shame — then nothing is more revolting than the remorse that follows. Crocodile's tears, that's what it is.

The Manager's impatience is functional: 'discussion' is his word for the part of drama that belongs to the rehearsal room, not the stage — he wants the wound, not the wound's theory.

THE MANAGER. Let's come to the point. This is only discussion.

The Father's sack metaphor is his most polished move — he aestheticises evasion into epistemology, asking for sympathy as the price of context.

THE FATHER. Very good, sir! A fact is like a sack — it won't stand up when it's empty. For it to stand up, you have to put into it the reason and sentiment which have caused it to exist. I couldn't possibly know that after his death they had decided to come back here, that they were in misery, and that she *[Pointing to the Mother.]* had gone to work as a seamstress, in a shop of Madame Pace's kind.

The Step-Daughter's ironic 'high-class modiste' is a guided tour of the apparatus of respectable exploitation — she names the machine before she names what it processed.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. A real high-class modiste, gentlemen. In appearance she dresses the leaders of the best society — but she arranges matters so those elegant ladies serve her purpose, and the rest of us — well, the rest of us serve a rather different purpose.

The Mother's appeal to credibility is the plea of a woman who knows she is the least credible witness to her own victimisation.

THE MOTHER. You will believe me, gentlemen, that it never entered my mind that the old hag offered me work because she had her eye on my daughter.

The Step-Daughter's detailed account of the torn-dress scheme is told with cold precision — she has narrated this to herself many times, assembling the proof that the trap was designed.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Poor Mother! Do you know, sir, what that woman did when I brought her back the work my mother had finished? She would point out to me that I had torn one of my dresses, and she would give it back to my mother to mend. It was I who paid for it, always I; while this poor creature here believed she was sacrificing herself for me and these two children here, sitting up at night sewing Madame Pace's dresses.

The Manager's 'And one day you met there' is the director steering toward the scene — he has accepted his role as dramaturg of a real catastrophe.

THE MANAGER. And one day you met there...

The Step-Daughter's 'Superb!' is pure theatrical aggression: she dares the Manager to stage the scene that will destroy the Father's remaining dignity.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Him, him. Yes sir, an old client. There's a scene for you to play! Superb!

The Father's incomplete sentence and the word 'then' — not 'fortunately' or 'unfortunately' — is a man trying to fix the timeline before the Step-Daughter can.

THE FATHER. She, the Mother arrived just then...

The Step-Daughter's 'Almost in time' is the blade: it tells the room that 'in time' is the Father's revision, not the truth.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Almost in time.

The Father's insistence on 'in time' twice is a man trying to win a verdict by sheer repetition; 'I cannot look her in the face' is the only honest thing he has said.

THE FATHER *[crying out]*. No — in time. *In time*. Fortunately I recognized her... in time. And I took them back home with me to my house. You can imagine now her position and mine; she, as you see her, and I who cannot look her in the face.

She refuses the role assigned to her by the Father's narrative; her contempt strips away any pretense that respectability can coexist with what happened in Madame Pace's room.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Absurd! How can I possibly be expected — after *that* — to play the modest young miss, fit company for his damned aspirations of "a solid moral sanity"?

The Father builds an elaborate philosophical alibi in real time, sweating without knowing it; the argument that no single act defines a man is itself the most self-defining act in the play.

THE FATHER. For the drama lies all in this — in the conscience that I have, that each one of us has. We believe this conscience to be a single thing; but it is many-sided. So we have the illusion of being one person for all, of having a personality that is unique in all our acts. But it isn't true. We perceive this when, tragically perhaps, in something we do, we are caught up, suspended on a kind of hook. Then we see that all of us was not in that act, and that it would be an atrocious injustice to judge us by that action alone — as if all our existence were summed up in that one deed. Now do you understand the perfidy of this girl? *She* surprised me in a place where she ought not to have known me — and now seeks to attach to me a reality I could never have supposed I would have to assume, in a shameful and fleeting moment of my life. *[He is sweating through this speech. He has not noticed.]*

The Players function as a detached chorus here; the question punctures the Father's rhetoric by naming what he just did — confessed — while pretending to philosophise.

PLAYER 2. Pardon — did we just witness a *confession*?

Comic self-deprecation masks genuine awe; the actor recognises a performance within the performance, exposing the Father as a rehearsed self-defender rather than a spontaneous sufferer.

PLAYER 1 [*quietly impressed despite himself*]. I believe we did. And rehearsed, too. I never manage mine on the first take.

The Son's physical stillness is its own declaration; withholding his body from the scene is the only power he has, a refusal that costs him nothing and protects everything.

THE SON [*hands in his pockets, body not moving*]. Leave me alone. I don't come into this.

The Father's echo is not a question but a challenge; he needs the Son onstage to complete the family tableau and cannot accept that one of his characters might simply opt out.

THE FATHER. What? You don't come into this?

The Son draws a boundary using the language of contamination; being "mixed up" signals that he experiences the family story as a stain he fears will adhere to him.

THE SON. I've got nothing to do with it. And I don't want to have. You know perfectly well I wasn't made to be mixed up in all this with the rest of you.

The Step-Daughter weaponises class irony, casting herself as vulgar to expose the Son's pretension; the Manager is conscripted as witness to a shaming ritual the Son cannot escape.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. We are vulgar folk, sir. *He* is the fine gentleman. You may have noticed, Mr. Manager, that I fix him now and again with a look that makes him lower his eyes — because he knows what he did to me.

A single syllable of disbelief; the Son's incredulity is not innocence but an instinct to contest the record before it can be fixed against him on stage.

THE SON [*scarcely looking at her*]. I?

She delivers an indictment that reframes domestic coldness as economic violence; "mistress of the house" reclaims a dignity the Son's contempt had already stripped from her family.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. You — you! I owe my life on the streets to you. Did you, or did you not, deny us — I won't say the warmth of home, but even the bare hospitality that makes a guest feel at ease? We were intruders, come to disturb the kingdom of your *legitimacy*. I'd like Mr. Manager to witness certain scenes between him and me. He says I have tyrannised. It was *his* behaviour that made me insist on the reason I had come — with my mother, who is his mother too. *And I came as mistress of the house.*

The Players' joke is also a genuine alarm: these characters are generating unscripted drama that the theatrical apparatus cannot contain or redirect.

PLAYER 1 [*to Player 2*]. This is not in the script. I checked.

The Son attempts to neutralise the Step-Daughter by shifting from her accusation to his own narrative of humiliation; framing her as threatening and mercenary is his defence against the charge of cruelty.

THE SON. It's easy for them to put me always in the wrong. But imagine, gentlemen, the position of a son who sees arrive one day at his home a young woman of impudent bearing, asking for his father — with whom, who knows what business she has. Then she returns, bolder, with that child there. He has to watch her treat his father in an equivocal and confidential manner. She asks him for money — in a way that lets one suppose he must give it. Must. Because he has every obligation.

The Father's admission is oddly calm — nearly proud; acknowledging the debt to the Mother is also a way of positioning himself as honourable, blunting the Son's implicit charge of exploitation.

THE FATHER. But I have, in fact, this obligation. I owe it to your mother.

The Son retreats behind the word "unrealised" as both self-diagnosis and escape hatch; to name himself incomplete is to argue that no complete action — and therefore no complete guilt — can be attributed to him.

THE SON. How should I know? When had I ever seen or heard of her? One day there arrive with her [*Indicating Step-Daughter.*] that lad and this baby here. I am told: "This is your mother. Also." I divine from her manner why they have come home. I had rather not say what I feel about it. I shouldn't even care to confess it to myself. No action can therefore be hoped for from me in this affair. Believe me, sir — I am an "unrealised" character. Leave me out of it, I beg you.

The Father senses the philosophical leverage in the Son's self-erasure and starts to turn it back on him, but the Son cuts him off before the trap closes.

THE FATHER. What? It is just because you are so that...

The Son's counter-attack shifts the ground from what he is to who has the right to say so; absent fathering forfeits the right to define — or judge — a child.

THE SON. How do you know what I am like? When did you ever *bother your head* about me?

The Father co-opts the Mother's tears as evidence for his own case, pointing her out to the Manager like an exhibit; genuine pain is being stage-managed in front of a stage manager.

THE FATHER. I admit it. I admit it. But isn't that a situation in itself? This aloofness of yours, so cruel to me and to your mother, who comes home and sees you almost for the first time as a grown man, who doesn't recognise you but knows you are her son... [*Pointing out the **Mother** to the **Manager**.*] See, she's crying!

Three words of flat contempt; the Step-Daughter refuses the Mother's grief as sentimental weakness, and her coldness here is the measure of how completely she has closed herself to softness.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER [*without looking at the **Mother***]. Like a fool.

The Father narrates the Boy's suffering while using it to pressure the Son; the Boy's silence becomes a weapon the Father wields, turning a mute child's pain into dramatic argument.

THE FATHER [*indicating Step-Daughter*]. She can't stand him, you know. [*Then referring again to the Son.*] He says he doesn't come into the affair, whereas he is really the hinge of the whole action. Look at that lad who is always clinging to his mother, frightened and humiliated. It is on account of this fellow here. Possibly his situation is the most painful of all. He feels himself more a stranger than the others — mortified at being brought into a home out of charity, as it were. [*In confidence.*] The image of his father. Hardly talks at all.

The Manager's pragmatism exposes the theatre's ruthlessness: inconvenient bodies — especially children — are simply edited out; the stage cannot afford what it cannot use.

THE MANAGER. Oh, we'll cut him out. You've no notion what a nuisance boys are on the stage...

The Father maps the whole catastrophe with the detachment of a playwright describing his own work; the lucidity is disturbing — he has already aestheticised the deaths and abandonment into a coherent dramatic arc.

THE FATHER. He disappears soon, you know. And the baby too. She is the first to vanish from the scene. The drama consists finally in this: when that mother re-enters my house, her family — born outside of it and superimposed on the original — ends with the loss of the little girl, the tragedy of the boy, and the flight of the elder daughter. It cannot go on, because it is foreign to its surroundings. So we three remain — I, the mother, that son — and find ourselves strange to one another. We live in an atmosphere of cold desolation — the revenge, as he [*Indicating the Son.*] scornfully said, of this damned experimenting of mine. When faith is lacking, it becomes impossible to create certain states of happiness.

PART III — THE BARGAIN

The Manager's resistance softens into appetite; he smells a commercial opportunity and reframes intrusion as inspiration.

THE MANAGER. There is something in what you say. I assure you all this interests me very much. I begin to think there's the stuff for a drama in all this, and not a bad drama either.

The Step-Daughter seizes the moment to assert her centrality, reminding everyone that she — not the Father — is the drama's engine.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER [*coming forward*]. When you've got a character like me.

The Father silences her because her bluntness threatens the careful seduction he is engineering; control masks panic.

THE FATHER [shutting her up, all excited to learn the decision of the *Manager*]. You be quiet!

The Manager's pause is professional instinct: he is already calculating casting, budget, and novelty value rather than listening to pain.

THE MANAGER [reflecting, heedless of interruption]. It's new... hem... yes...

The Father's single-word echo is a salesman's close — he mirrors the Manager's own language to seal the deal.

THE FATHER. Absolutely new!

The Manager's grudging admiration reveals he has already shifted from resistance to negotiation; the audacity has won him over.

THE MANAGER. You've got a nerve though, I must say, to come here and fling it at me like this...

The Father reaches for an ontological claim — destiny, not ambition — to dignify what could look like desperation.

THE FATHER. You will understand, sir, born as we are for the stage...

The Manager asserts professional hierarchy to deflect the uncanny; reducing them to amateurs makes them manageable.

THE MANAGER. Are you amateur actors then? Because we, sir, are a professional company, with a season to fill.

The Father begins to articulate a philosophical distinction the Manager will not want; the sentence trails because philosophy embarrasses commerce.

THE FATHER. No. I say born for the stage, because...

The Manager cuts off the metaphysics with flattery, trying to restore normal theatrical transaction and avoid deeper discomfort.

THE MANAGER. Oh, nonsense. You're an old hand, you know.

The Father confesses his own theatricality while simultaneously excusing it — passion becomes performance, and he knows it, and uses knowing it as cover.

THE FATHER. No sir, no. We act that rôle for which we have been cast, that rôle which we are given in life. And in my own case, passion itself, as usually happens, becomes a trifle theatrical when it is exalted.

The Manager tries to offload the creative burden onto an absent author, keeping himself safely administrative and uninvolved.

THE MANAGER. Well, well, that will do. But you see, without an author... I could give you the address of an author if you like...

The Father refuses the escape route; he needs the Manager complicit, not merely a facilitator, so the guilt of creation is shared.

THE FATHER. No, no. Look here! You must be the author.

The Manager's bewilderment is genuine but short-lived; the question already contains the seed of assent.

THE MANAGER. I? What are you talking about?

The Father presses the advantage with naked insistence, stripping away all pretence of a polite request.

THE FATHER. Yes, you, you! Why not?

The Manager's objection is bureaucratic, not moral; he defines himself by role, not capacity, which is exactly the opening the Father needs.

THE MANAGER. Because I have never been an author: that's why.

The Father flatters the Manager by democratising authorship, simultaneously devaluing art and elevating the Manager's self-image.

THE FATHER. Then why not turn author now? Everybody does it. You don't want any special qualities. Your task is made much easier by the fact that we are all here alive before you...

The Manager's two-word refusal is unconvincing even to himself; the brevity signals wavering, not resolve.

THE MANAGER. It won't do.

The Father uses the present tense — live, not performed — to collapse the distance between their suffering and theatrical product.

THE FATHER. What? When you see us live our drama...

The Manager retreats to craft as a defensive boundary: he can feel the pull but needs the alibi of needing a writer.

THE MANAGER. Yes, that's all right. But you want someone to write it.

The Father redefines authorship as stenography, removing all creative responsibility from the Manager to make acceptance frictionless.

THE FATHER. No, no. Someone to take it down, possibly, while we play it, scene by scene! It will be enough to sketch it out at first, and then try it over.

The Manager's hedged language — almost, bit of an idea, might — is the sound of a professional rationalising surrender as experiment.

THE MANAGER. Well... I am almost tempted. It's a bit of an idea. One might have a shot at it.

The Father moves immediately to demonstration, knowing that once the Manager sees a scene he will be unable to let go.

THE FATHER. Of course. You'll see what scenes will come out of it. I can give you one, at once...

Capitulation arrives disguised as decisiveness; the Manager's brisk logistics reveal he is now fully captured, the schedule forgotten.

THE MANAGER [he is hooked, in spite of himself; the schedule he came in trying to defend is no longer in his mind]. God help me, it tempts me. I'd like to have a go at it. Let's try it out. Come with me to my office. [Turning to the **Actors**.] You are at liberty for a bit, but don't step out of the theatre for long. In a quarter of an hour, twenty minutes, all back here again. [To the **Father**.] We'll see what can be done. Who knows if we don't get something really extraordinary out of it?

The Father's question about bringing the Characters is a power move: he ensures the whole wound accompanies him into the room where deals are made.

THE FATHER. There's no doubt about it. They [Indicating the **Characters**.] had better come with us too, hadn't they?

The Manager's repeated 'come on' and punctuality instruction reveal he has mentally recast himself as director of their reality, not merely a host.

THE MANAGER. Yes, yes. Come on! come on! [Moves away and then turning to the **Actors**.] Be punctual, please! [Manager and the Six **Characters** cross the stage and go off. The other **Actors** remain, looking at one another in astonishment.]

The Leading Man's wounded vanity speaks first; 'furniture' exposes his fear that his professional identity has been rendered irrelevant in seconds.

PLAYER 1 (AS LEADING MAN). Is he serious? He has taken six strangers into his office and left us standing here like furniture.

The Juvenile Lead's soft correction hints at unease rather than insight — he senses something wrong but cannot name it.

PLAYER 3 (AS JUVENILE LEAD). They are not ordinary strangers.

The Leading Lady articulates what unsettles everyone: these visitors arrived with their catastrophe pre-formed, bypassing the normal theatrical process entirely.

PLAYER 2 (AS LEADING LADY). No. Ordinary strangers do not arrive with a tragedy already rehearsed.

The Leading Man's bitter sarcasm about twenty minutes collapses artistic ambition into workplace grievance, revealing his real concern is scheduling.

PLAYER 1. And now he wants us to make a play out of them. In twenty minutes.

The Leading Lady's throwaway anecdote positions the Manager as a reckless improviser, subtly undermining his authority while appearing to defend it.

PLAYER 2. He once staged the Nativity in fifteen.

The Juvenile Lead's tentative observation signals the company beginning to crack — curiosity overtaking professional resentment.

PLAYER 3. Perhaps there is a play.

The Leading Lady reduces everything to labour economics; her cynicism is also a self-protective refusal to be moved by the Characters' pain.

PLAYER 2. There is always a play. The question is whether anyone is being paid to be in it.

The Ingénue's demand for a better part is comic precisely because she has no idea she is already inside the drama the Characters brought with them.

PLAYER 1 (AS L'INGÉNUE) *[a line about vanity, delivered with no irony whatsoever].* I only know this: if the morning continues like this, I shall require a better part.

The Door-keeper's two-layered performance — cap in hand, Leading Man posture visible — shows the actor unable to fully inhabit a minor role when dignity is at stake.

PLAYER 1 (AS DOOR-KEEPER) *[the cap forgotten in his hand; the Leading Man's posture leaking through the doorman's apology].* I only let them in.

The Leading Lady's crisp dismissal turns the Door-keeper's admission into a moral verdict, implicating him in whatever follows.

PLAYER 2. That is not a defence.

The Door-keeper's final excuse is a chilling displacement: the Characters' air of inevitability was so strong it overrode all professional gatekeeping instinct.

PLAYER 1 (AS DOOR-KEEPER). They looked expected.

The Prompter's question — comic in timing — highlights that the normal division between performance and record-keeping has dissolved; nobody knows who is doing what.

PLAYER 3 (AS PROMPTER). Am I taking this down?

The Leading Lady's instruction to treat everything as potential evidence marks the moment the company stops watching a curiosity and starts fearing consequence.

PLAYER 2. Take everything down. It may be evidence.

*Thus talking, the **Actors** leave the stage; some going out by the little door at the back; others retiring to their dressing-rooms.*

Act Two — The Theatre

PART I — THE SETUP

The stage call-bells ring to warn the company that the play is about to begin again.

The Step-Daughter comes out of the Manager's office carrying the Child-bundle and dragging the Boy-chair behind her. As she comes out of the office, she cries: —

Her refusal is self-protective theater: she won't be stage-managed, but she also seizes the stage the moment she steps onto it with the children.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Nonsense! nonsense! Do it yourselves! I'm not going to mix myself up in this mess. *[Turning to the Child-bundle in her arms and coming quickly onto the stage.]* Come on, Rosetta, let's run! *[She drags the Boy-chair to a spot a little behind her and leaves it there, leaning.]*

The stage darkens around her. The shower — a tight vertical column of light from a single overhead source — falls on the Step-Daughter only. The pianist begins Satie's Gymnopédie No. 1, slow and child-haunted, beneath what follows. She kneels with the Child-bundle held against her chest, the Boy-chair leaning a short pace away. She speaks the next monologue live, alone in the column of light.

Addressing the Child is a way of speaking the unspeakable aloud — the fountain is real suffering that cardboard props can never hold, and she already knows how this ends.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[bends over the Child-bundle and takes the cloth between her hands as if it were a small face].* My little darling! You're frightened, aren't you? You don't know where we are. *[Pretending to reply to a question of the Child.]* What is the stage? It's a place, baby, where people play at being serious — and we've got to act a comedy now, dead serious. You're in it too. A garden — a fountain — look — just suppose, little one, it's here, right in the middle. It's all pretence, my pet. All make-believe here. Better to imagine it, because if they fix it up for you, it'll only be painted cardboard — for the rockery, the water, the plants. Ah, but I think a baby like this would sooner have a make-believe fountain than a real one. What a joke it'll be for the others! But for you, alas, not such a joke. You who are real, baby dear, and really play by a real fountain, big and green and beautiful, with bamboos around and a whole lot of little ducks swimming. — *[She turns, sets the Child-bundle down carefully beside her, and reaches for the coat hanging on the Boy-chair. She takes the coat by the sleeve as if she were taking the Boy by the arm.]* What have you got there? *[She slides her hand into the coat pocket and finds the revolver. She holds it up briefly in the column of light, then returns it to the pocket.]* Ah! Where did you get this? Idiot! If I'd been in your place, instead of killing myself I'd have shot one of those two — or both. Father and son.

The piano dies on her last word. The shower holds on her for one more breath, then releases. The working lights come up. The Step-Daughter is alone on the upper platform with the Child-bundle and the Boy-chair. The Boy and the Child are silent objects again.

The Father's cheerful efficiency is a bid for control; 'it's all fixed up' erases the Step-Daughter's agency just as he erased it before.

THE FATHER. Come on, come on dear! Come here for a minute! We've arranged everything. It's all fixed up.

The Manager's excitement betrays him — he is now a collaborator in the spectacle, no longer a neutral arbiter of theatrical convention.

THE MANAGER *[also excited].* If you please, young lady, there are one or two points to settle still. Will you come along?

Her sarcastic 'what's the good' punctures the Manager's optimism; she follows anyway, showing she is trapped inside the story she claims to despise.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[following him towards the office].* Ouff! what's the good, if you've arranged everything. *[The Father, Manager and Step-Daughter go back into the office again (off) for a moment. At the same time, The Son followed by The Mother, comes out.]*

His trapped fury — 'I can't even get away' — reveals that contempt is the Son's only defense against a family drama he refuses to perform but cannot escape.

THE SON *[looking at the three entering office]. Oh this is fine. Fine. And to think I can't even get away. [The Mother attempts to look at him, but lowers her eyes immediately when he turns away from her. She then sits down. She gathers the Child-bundle into her lap and draws the Boy-chair close beside her. She casts a glance again at the Son, and speaks with humble tones, trying to draw him into conversation.]*

The Mother's question is not rhetorical: she genuinely believes her silent suffering should spare others, and she is devastated that the Son will not even grant her that.

THE MOTHER. Isn't my punishment the worst of all? *[Then seeing from the Son's manner that he will not bother himself about her.]* My God. Why are you so cruel? Isn't it enough for one person to carry all this? Must you make others see it too?

The Mother rises. She takes one step toward the Son, the Child-bundle still in her arms.

Two syllables that carry the whole weight of maternal love and rejection — she reaches for him knowing he will not take the hand.

THE MOTHER *[barely].* My son —

The Son turns away before the word is finished. She stops where she is; the unfinished word stays in the air between them. After a moment she sits again, and holds the Child-bundle a little lower, as though it had grown heavier in her arms.

The Son exposes the Father's philosophizing as self-serving theater; by revealing the parents' private life, he destroys the very idealization that shielded him from shame.

THE SON *[half to himself, meaning the Mother to hear — eyes on the floor].* And they want to put it on the stage. If there was at least a reason for it. He thinks he has got at the meaning of it all. Just as if each one of us, in every circumstance of life, couldn't find his own explanation of it. *[Pauses.]* He complains he was discovered in a place where he ought not to have been seen, in a moment of his life that should have stayed hidden. And what about my case? Haven't I had to reveal what no son ought ever to reveal — how father and mother live, and are man and wife, for themselves — quite apart from that idea of father and mother which we give them?

The Player's withdrawal from notation is the first crack in professional detachment — the story has crossed a line that art's record-keeping cannot ethically follow.

PLAYER 3 *[very quietly, the pencil gone still in their hand].* Mon Dieu. I've stopped writing it down. I don't want a record of this one.

The Mother hides her face in her hands. From the dressing-rooms and the little door at the back of the stage the Actors and Stage Manager return, followed by the Property Man, and the Prompter. At the same moment, The Manager comes out of his office, accompanied by the Father and the Step-Daughter.

The Manager claps the rehearsal back to order to reassert institutional authority over raw human material that has begun to feel dangerously real.

THE MANAGER *[trying to take the rehearsal back, his director's voice returning].* Come on, come on, ladies and gentlemen! Right — you there, machinist!

Two words, but Player 1 cannot suppress Leading Man habit even in a bit role — vanity survives every context, underlining theatre's inescapable artifice.

PLAYER 1 (AS MACHINIST) *[two words; somehow still managing to deliver them as a Leading Man].* Yes, sir.

Stage directions for a domestic horror: the Manager reduces the Step-Daughter's trauma to a lighting problem and a door, revealing theatre's brutal economy.

THE MANAGER. Fix up the white parlor with the floral decorations. Two wings and a drop with a door will do. Hurry up!

The Machinist runs off at once to prepare the scene, and arranges it while The Manager talks with the Stage Manager, the Property Man, and the Prompter on matters of detail.

The sofa question is not trivial — the correct furniture is a piece of evidence, and the Manager's casualness signals he does not yet understand what he is staging.

THE MANAGER [to *Property Man*]. Just have a look, and see if there isn't a sofa or divan in the wardrobe...

Property Man's flat certainty — 'it has always been the sofa we have' — is comic institutional inertia, but it also marks the theatre's inability to meet the specific truth of lived experience.

PLAYER 2 (AS PROPERTY MAN) [the *Property Man's* voice, flat and certain]. There's the green one. It is the sofa we have. It has always been the sofa we have.

The Step-Daughter's insistence on yellow is not vanity; the exact sofa is a forensic detail that anchors her memory of degradation and cannot be substituted.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. No no! Green won't do. It was yellow, ornamented with flowers — very large! and most comfortable!

The theatre simply does not stock the particular object of real shame — an admission of the medium's fundamental insufficiency.

PLAYER 2 (AS PROPERTY MAN). There isn't one like that.

The Manager's 'it doesn't matter' is the production's original sin: he privileges convenience over fidelity, and the Step-Daughter will punish him for it.

THE MANAGER. It doesn't matter. Use the one we've got.

Her 'most important' is not stubbornness — she knows that wrong props will make her truth look like fiction, and she is fighting to preserve its reality.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Doesn't matter? It's most important!

The Manager silences her to assert directorial sovereignty, but the demand for a shop window also shows he grasps the scene's commercial-erotic geography.

THE MANAGER. We're only trying it now. Please don't interfere. [To *Property Man*.] See if we've got a shop window — long and narrowish.

The mahogany table and pale blue envelope are material relics of the transaction — she names them with the precision of someone who has never forgotten a single object in that room.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. And the little table! The little mahogany table for the pale blue envelope!

Gilt instead of mahogany: another substitution that cheapens the scene's moral economy without the Manager noticing the difference.

PLAYER 2 (AS PROPERTY MAN) [to *Manager*]. There's that little gilt one.

The Manager's breezy acceptance reveals he is dressing a set, not reconstructing a crime — and he cannot yet feel the gap between the two.

THE MANAGER. That'll do fine.

The Father's single word is a small, revealing vanity — he wants the mirror there, which means he still watches himself even in scenes of his own disgrace.

THE FATHER. A mirror.

The screen is not a prop preference but a privacy demand — without it the scene cannot be staged as she lived it, half-hidden, half-visible.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. And the screen! There must be a screen. Otherwise how am I to *manage*?

The Property Man's easy abundance ('any amount of them') inadvertently mocks the scene's singularity; the theatre is well-stocked in screens for shame.

PLAYER 2 (AS PROPERTY MAN). That's all right, Miss. We've got any amount of them.

The Manager's question about clothes pegs signals that he now understands the room's function — this is the moment he becomes a co-author of the exposure.

THE MANAGER [to the *Step-Daughter*]. We want some clothes pegs too, don't we?

She knows the wall, the screen, the exact placement — the knowledge of a person who has memorized every object in a room they wanted to escape.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[she knows the geography of that room — knows where Madame Pace kept everything].* Yes. Several. There were always several. On the wall by the screen.

Bringing all the pegs is both logistical and theatrical overkill — the Manager is compensating for his inability to supply the right sofa with a surplus of smaller truths.

THE MANAGER. See how many we've got and bring them all.

Property Man's wordless efficiency is the theatre's unsentimentality — it services the scene without asking what happened there.

PLAYER 2 (AS PROPERTY MAN) *[a half-nod; she is already on her way].* Right.

*The **Property Man** hurries off to obey his orders. While he is putting the things in their places, the **Manager** talks to the **Prompter** and then with the **Characters** and the **Actors**.*

Asking the Prompter to do something 'out of the ordinary' quietly admits that this production has already left ordinary theatrical procedure behind.

THE MANAGER *[to **Prompter**].* Take your seat. Look here: this is the outline of the scenes, act by act. *[Hands him some sheets of paper.]* And now I'm going to ask you to do something out of the ordinary.

The Prompter's doubled question reveals surprise that the living performance will need a written record at all — the Characters blur the line between scripted and spontaneous.

PLAYER 3 (AS PROMPTER) *[looking up from the book; an unusual request to receive at this hour].* Take it down in shorthand? Sir — *in shorthand?*

The Manager's pleasant surprise exposes how improvised the whole enterprise has become; he is solving a problem he did not foresee because he did not foresee these Characters.

THE MANAGER *[pleasantly surprised].* Exactly! Can you do shorthand?

The Prompter's understated 'a little' is modest competence hedging against an extraordinary assignment — he senses this shorthand will record something that should not be forgotten.

PLAYER 3 (AS PROMPTER). Yes, a little.

The stage hand fetching paper is the theatre's bureaucratic apparatus mobilizing for something it cannot fully contain — the administrative prepares to witness the existential.

THE MANAGER. Good! *[Turning to a **Stage Hand**.]* Go and get some paper from my office, plenty, as much as you can find. *[The **Stage Hand** goes off, and soon returns with a handful of paper which he gives to the **Prompter**.]*

The Manager is now directing the actors to become audience, inverting the normal hierarchy — the Characters have displaced the professionals from the center of the stage.

THE MANAGER *[to **Prompter**].* You follow the scenes as we play them, and try and get the points down, at any rate the most important ones. *[Then addressing the **Actors**.]* Clear the stage, ladies and gentlemen! Come over here *[Pointing to the left.]* and listen attentively.

The Leading Lady's unfinished objection is professional anxiety — she senses her role is being evacuated before she knows what will replace it.

PLAYER 2 (AS LEADING LADY). But, excuse me, we...

The Manager's reassurance 'you won't have to improvise' is ironic: the Characters will force exactly the kind of unscripted reality that trained actors fear most.

THE MANAGER *[guessing her thought].* Don't worry! You won't have to improvise.

The Leading Man's joke about applauding all season is vanity turning to acid — he resents the demotion and wraps it in theatrical gossip to save face.

PLAYER 1 (AS LEADING MAN). What have we to do then — sit and applaud? I can do that. I've been doing that all season — at every other company's premiere in the canton, in fact.

The Manager reduces the Characters to a demonstration piece — 'they're going to act now' — treating their existence as a pedagogical exercise for his company.

THE MANAGER. Nothing. For the moment you just watch and listen. Everybody will get his part written out afterwards. At present we're going to try the thing as best we can. They're going to act now.

The Father's bewilderment at the word 'rehearsal' cuts to the philosophical heart: Characters do not rehearse their fixed reality, they simply live it.

THE FATHER *[as if fallen from the clouds into the confusion of the stage]*. We? What do you mean, if you please, by a rehearsal?

The Manager's clarification — the rehearsal is for the Actors, not the Characters — inadvertently concedes that the Characters need no preparation because they already are.

THE MANAGER. A rehearsal for them. *[Points to the Actors.]*

The Father's unfinished sentence performs his point: a Character does not argue for its existence, it simply is the argument, and the incomplete clause proves it.

THE FATHER. But since we are the characters...

The Manager's lecture about the book and the prompter's box locates theatrical authority in text, which is precisely what these bookless Characters destabilize.

THE MANAGER. All right: "characters" then, if you insist on calling yourselves such. But here, my dear sir, the characters don't act. Here the actors do the acting. The characters are there, in the "book" *[Pointing towards Prompter's box.]* — when there is a "book"!

The Father pivots the argument: the Actors' desire to 'be' the Characters is proof that the Characters possess a reality the Actors can only approximate.

THE FATHER. I won't contradict you; but excuse me, the actors aren't the characters. They want to be, they pretend to be, don't they? Now if these gentlemen here are fortunate enough to have us alive before them...

The Manager's sarcastic 'grand' reveals his fear — if the Characters perform themselves, the theatre's mediating function, and his own authority, become redundant.

THE MANAGER. Oh this is grand! You want to come before the public yourselves then?

'As we are' is the Father's entire manifesto compressed — unmediated, uninterpreted, unacted; it is also the most dangerous thing you can put on a stage.

THE FATHER. As we are...

The Manager's irony backfires: 'magnificent spectacle' is exactly what the Characters offer and exactly what the theatre cannot reproduce — he has stated his own defeat.

THE MANAGER. I can assure you it would be a magnificent spectacle!

The Leading Man's 'furniture with opinions' is wounded professional pride, but it accidentally names the Actors' structural role — decoration for a drama that outgrows them.

PLAYER 1 (AS LEADING MAN). What is the use of us here, then? Furniture with opinions?

The Manager's laughter covers genuine unease; casting 'they cast themselves' surrenders authorial control while pretending to exercise it.

THE MANAGER. You're not seriously going to pretend you can act? It makes me laugh! *[The Actors laugh.]* There, you see, they are laughing at the notion. But, by the way, I must cast the parts. That won't be difficult. They cast themselves. *[To the Second Lady Lead.]* You play the Mother. *[To the Father.]* We must find her a name.

The Father's provision of the real name is an act of fidelity to truth that the theatre will immediately refuse — the gap between the real and the representable opens here.

THE FATHER. Amalia, sir.

The Manager's objection to the real name is theatrical protocol, but it exposes the medium's need to sanitize lived identity into manageable fiction.

THE MANAGER. But that is the real name of your wife. We don't want to call her by her real name.

The Father hears his own words 'ring false' the moment representation enters — a precise, devastating diagnosis of what theatre does to real experience.

THE FATHER. Why not, if it's her name?... Still, perhaps, if that lady must... *[Makes a slight motion of the hand to indicate the **Second Lady Lead.**]* I see this woman here *[Means the **Mother.**]* as Amalia. But do as you like. *[Gets more and more confused.]* I don't know what to say to you. Already I can hear my own words ring false...

The Manager's brisk efficiency papers over the Father's vertigo; assigning names and roles, he reclaims directorial ground by reducing persons to functions.

THE MANAGER. Don't you worry about it. It'll be our job to find the right tones. And as for her name, if you want her to be Amalia, Amalia she is. If you don't like it, we'll find another! For the moment though, we'll call the characters in this way: *[To **Juvenile Lead.**]* You are the Son. *[To the **Leading Lady.**]* You naturally are the Step-Daughter...

Her laugh is not at the Leading Lady personally but at the obscenity of the substitution — that woman cannot contain what the Step-Daughter carries, and she knows it instantly.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[a single hard laugh, head turning]*. What? What? I — that woman there?

The Manager's anger is directorial impatience, but it also betrays that he has chosen the Leading Lady and cannot afford to have the choice mocked.

THE MANAGER *[angry]*. What is there to laugh at?

The Leading Lady's demand for respect and 'reasonable lighting' is vanity, but the lighting demand is also technically urgent — she knows she will look wrong in this scene.

PLAYER 2 (AS LEADING LADY) *[indignant]*. Nobody has ever dared to laugh at me. Nobody. I insist on being treated with respect — and reasonable lighting — otherwise I go.

The Step-Daughter's quick correction shifts from contempt to something almost like pity — she is not laughing at the woman but at the impossibility of the task assigned to her.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. No, no, excuse me... I'm not laughing at you...

The Manager tries to smooth over the insult with flattery, using institutional authority to silence the Step-Daughter's instinctive rejection of her surrogate.

THE MANAGER *[to Step-Daughter]*. You should feel honored to be played by...

The Leading Lady's contempt reveals wounded vanity: she heard 'that woman' as dismissal, and fires back before thinking, exposing how brittle professional pride is.

PLAYER 2 (AS LEADING LADY) *[at once, contemptuously]*. "That woman there"...

The Step-Daughter refuses the consolation of representation; her self is not transferable, and she knows it — this is grief dressed as aesthetic objection.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. But I wasn't speaking of *you*, you know. I was speaking of myself — whom I can't see in you at all. I don't know quite how to put it — but no, you really aren't anything like me.

The Father seizes the opening, pivoting from personal grievance to metaphysics; philosophy is his armour whenever raw feeling threatens to surface.

THE FATHER. True. Here's the point. Look here, sir, our temperaments, our souls...

The Manager deflates the Father's intellectual posturing with crude pragmatism: the theatre owns the characters now, and souls are not on the running-sheet.

THE MANAGER. Temperament, soul — to hell with all that! Do you suppose the spirit of the piece is in you? Nothing of the kind!

The Father's question is not rhetorical innocence but wounded possessiveness — he cannot bear that his interiority might belong to someone else to dispose of.

THE FATHER. What, haven't we our own temperaments, our own souls?

The Manager's speech is a power grab cloaked as craft: he subordinates the characters' living pain to institutional process and professional reputation.

THE MANAGER. Not at all. Your soul or whatever you like to call it takes shape here. The actors give body and form to it, voice and gesture. And my actors have given voice to material far more lofty than this little drama of yours — which may or may not hold up on the stage. But if it does, the merit of it, believe me, will be due to my actors.

The Father's 'terrible suffering' is real but also strategic — he weaponises vulnerability to reclaim moral ground from the Manager's dismissal.

THE FATHER. I don't dare contradict you, sir; but, believe me, it is a terrible suffering for us who are as we are, with these bodies of ours, these features to see...

The Manager's impatience with make-up as cure-all betrays a director's faith that surface can substitute for essence, the very delusion the play attacks.

THE MANAGER [cutting him short and out of patience]. Good heavens! The make-up will remedy all that, man, the make-up...

The Father's quiet insistence on voice and gesture is his most precise argument: the body that carries shame cannot be simply painted over.

THE FATHER. Maybe. But the voice, the gestures...

The Manager's decree — 'you cannot exist on stage' — is the play's central violence stated baldly, an ontological eviction issued as a stage direction.

THE MANAGER. Now, look here! On the stage, you as yourself, cannot exist. The actor here acts you, and that's an end to it!

The Father suddenly grasps why the Author abandoned them: being staged means being falsified, and that falsification is more unbearable than non-existence.

THE FATHER. I understand. And now I think I see why our author who conceived us as we are, all alive, didn't want to put us on the stage after all. I haven't the least desire to offend your actors. Far from it! But when I think that I am to be acted by... I don't know by whom...

The Leading Man's performed dignity — chin lifted, bearing arranged — is itself an act, revealing that actors perform even when offstage, always auditioning.

PLAYER 1 (AS LEADING MAN) [on his dignity — chin lifted, the bearing arranged]. By me, if you've no objection.

The Father's elaborate courtesy toward the Leading Man is a trap: the bow and 'honored' set up the devastating 'but' that erases the compliment entirely.

THE FATHER [with a small bow toward Player 1]. Honored, I assure you, sir. Still, I must say that try as this gentleman may, with all his good will and wonderful art, to absorb me into himself...

The Leading Man's vanity cracks the moment irony is suspected; 'wonderful art' undoes him because he cannot tell sincerity from condescension.

PLAYER 1 (AS LEADING MAN) [the dignity cracking]. Oh — come off it. "Wonderful art." He says it like he means it. Withdraw that, please.

The Father presses the wound: however skilled the performance, the actor can only produce his own version of the Father, not the Father himself.

THE FATHER. The performance he will give, even doing his best with make-up to look like me...

The Leading Man retreats into laughter, letting the audience share the joke — but the laugh is defensive, a way to avoid conceding the Father's point.

PLAYER 1 (AS LEADING MAN). It will certainly be a bit difficult! [The Actors laugh.]

The Father's long speech on criticism is really a pre-emptive bid for interpretive authority: he wants the last word on his own story before it is taken from him.

THE FATHER. Exactly! It will be difficult to act me as I really am. The effect will be more — apart from the make-up — how he supposes I am, how he senses me — if he senses me at all — and not how I, inside myself, feel myself to be. So it seems to me that anyone whose job it becomes to criticise us should take this into account...

The Manager's impatient pivot to logistics is a refusal to engage: he cannot answer the Father's argument, so he simply buries it under stage management.

THE MANAGER. Heavens! The man's starting to think about the critics now! Let them say what they like. It's up to us to put on the play if we can. *[Looking around.]* Come on! come on! Is the stage set? *[To the Actors and Characters.]* Stand back — stand back! Let me see, and don't let's lose any more time! *[To the Step-Daughter.]* Is it all right as it is now?

The Step-Daughter's flat 'I don't recognize the scene' is not scenic criticism but a statement of identity: the real place of her humiliation cannot be reproduced.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Well, to tell the truth, I don't recognize the scene.

The Manager's condescension — 'you can't possibly suppose' — masks genuine limitation; theatre is always approximation, and he knows it but will not admit it.

THE MANAGER. My dear lady, you can't possibly suppose that we can construct that shop of Madame Pace piece by piece here? *[To the Father.]* You said a white room with flowered wall paper, didn't you?

The Father's single 'Yes' is the stillest moment so far: bare confirmation, all the intellectual scaffolding stripped away, the room suddenly real and close.

THE FATHER. Yes.

The Manager's brisk furniture-moving — table, envelope — reduces the site of the Step-Daughter's degradation to props on a checklist, obscene in its efficiency.

THE MANAGER. Well then. We've got the furniture right more or less. Bring that little table a bit further forward. *[The Stage Hands obey the order. To Property Man.]* You go and find an envelope, if possible, a pale blue one; and give it to that gentleman. *[Indicates Father.]*

The Property Man's mundane question about the envelope's ordinariness underlines the absurdity: an instrument of shame is being requisitioned like a paperclip.

PLAYER 2 (AS PROPERTY MAN). An ordinary envelope?

Father and Manager speaking in unison — the only moment they agree — signals how the bureaucratic and the personal both need the same ordinary container for the transaction.

THE MANAGER AND THE FATHER. Yes, yes, an ordinary envelope.

The Property Man's crisp exit enacts institutional obedience: the machinery of theatre moves without moral pause, however freighted the object it fetches.

PLAYER 2 (AS PROPERTY MAN). At once, sir. *[Exit.]*

The Manager's double correction — Leading Lady then Step-Daughter — exposes the substitution at the heart of theatre; one woman is simply swapped for another.

THE MANAGER. Ready, everyone! First scene — the Young Lady. *[The Leading Lady comes forward.]* No, no, you must wait. I meant her *[Indicating the Step-Daughter.]* You just watch —

The Step-Daughter's hunger to 'live it' is not performance pride but compulsion: she needs to re-enact her degradation because only she can carry its full weight.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[adding at once]*. How I'll play it, how I'll live it!...

The Leading Lady's offended retort is professional reflex; she misreads the Step-Daughter's compulsion as a competitive slight rather than existential desperation.

PLAYER 2 (AS LEADING LADY) *[offended]*. I'll live it too, you may be sure, as soon as I begin!

The Manager's 'as if lost' reveals the first crack in his authority: he has been managing chaos all scene, and now even the cast list has a gap he cannot fill.

THE MANAGER *[with his hands to his head]*. Ladies and gentlemen, if you please! No more useless discussions! Scene I: the young lady with Madame Pace: Oh! *[Looks around as if lost.]* And this Madame Pace, where is she?

The Father's quiet 'She isn't with us' reopens the metaphysical problem just when the Manager thought he had closed it; Madame Pace exists on different terms.

THE FATHER. She isn't with us, sir.

The Manager's 'what the devil's to be done' is exasperation at the limit of his craft: you cannot cast a character who arrives on her own conditions.

THE MANAGER. Then what the devil's to be done?

The Father's 'she is alive too' asserts that Pace, like them, has autonomous fictional existence — a claim that will be proved, disturbingly, within moments.

THE FATHER. But she is alive too.

The Manager's 'but where is she' is a mundane question that exposes how theatre thinks in locations; existence without a mark on the stage plan is invisible.

THE MANAGER. Yes, but where is she?

The Father's request for the actresses' hats is both conjuring-trick and thesis: he believes the props of her trade can summon the character who needs them.

THE FATHER. One minute. Let me speak! *[Turning to the Actresses.]* If these ladies would be so good as to give me their hats for a moment...

The players' half-surprised, half-laughing chorus response captures the company's state throughout — unsettled but still treating the uncanny as comedy.

ALL THREE PLAYERS *[half surprised, half laughing, in chorus].*

The Manager's question about the hats is reasonable and completely beside the point; he has not yet grasped that the Father is performing a genuine summoning.

THE MANAGER. What are you going to do with the ladies' hats? *[The Actors laugh.]*

The Father extends the ritual — mantles too — building the haberdashery set with careful, almost priestly attention, each item an invocation.

THE FATHER. Oh nothing. I just want to put them on these pegs for a moment. And one of the ladies will be so kind as to take off her mantle...

The players' collective response (stage direction only) signals their compliance is grudging and bemused: the company is slowly ceding control without realising it.

ALL THREE PLAYERS.

Two players' separate reaction marks the moment the group begins to fracture — individuals distinguishing themselves from the chorus as unease grows.

TWO PLAYERS.

The Father's 'please be so kind' is genuine courtesy and also manipulation; politeness keeps the actors cooperating with a ritual they don't understand.

THE FATHER. To hang them up here for a moment. Please be so kind, will you?

The actors hanging their hats and cloaks enact the Father's will without comprehending it: the theatre company becomes unwitting participants in a séance.

ALL THREE PLAYERS *[taking off their hats, one or two also their cloaks, and going to hang them on the racks].*

The Father's 'on show' — two words — names the logic of the summons: Madame Pace is a creature of display, and she will come to where her merchandise is visible.

THE FATHER. Exactly; just like that, on show.

The Manager's 'May we know why?' is the voice of institutional reason confronting something it cannot categorise; he needs a rational explanation before he can proceed.

THE MANAGER. May we know why?

The Father's theory of summoning — that a character comes when her world is arranged — is Pirandello's thesis made literal: fiction is not written but called into being by conditions.

THE FATHER. I'll tell you. Who knows if, by arranging the stage for her, she doesn't come here herself, attracted by the very articles of her trade? *[Inviting the Actors to look towards the exit at back of stage.]* Look! Look!

PART II — THE APPARITION

*The door at the back of stage opens and **Madame Pace** enters and takes a few steps forward. She is a fat, oldish woman with puffy oxygenated hair, rouged and powdered, dressed with a comical elegance in black silk. Round her waist is a long silver chain from which hangs a pair of scissors. The audience should read her at first as absurd — an apparition out of a comic operetta, conjured from the costume department of every small shop in Lausanne that has ever overcharged a foreigner. She has come, however, from somewhere real: a back room off the rue de Bourg, where the accounts book lies open on a desk and a customer is waiting. The comedy is her front. The scissors at her waist are not. The **Step-Daughter** runs over to her at once amid the stupor of the actors.*

The Step-Daughter's cry is triumphant, not welcoming — Madame Pace's arrival vindicates her darkest testimony and strips the stage of any comfortable theatrical distance.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[turning towards her]*. There she is! There she is!

The Father's radiance reveals how badly he needs the stage to confirm his version of reality; Pace's arrival feels to him like vindication, not accusation.

THE FATHER *[radiant]*. It's she! I said so, didn't I? There she is!

The Manager's indignation is self-protective: what he cannot control or explain becomes, by reflex, a violation of the rules he is there to enforce.

THE MANAGER *[conquering his surprise, and then becoming indignant]*. What sort of a trick is this?

The Leading Man's existential check — hand to chest — betrays that the real threat is not the script but the sudden doubt about whether trained actors have any substance beside these intruders.

PLAYER 1 (AS LEADING MAN) *[almost at the same time — a hand pressed flat to his chest, as if checking he is still there]*. What's going to happen next? Have we lost the script entirely?

The Juvenile Lead retreats into bureaucracy (the casting list) because it is the only frame of reference left when reality overruns the rehearsal room.

PLAYER 3 (AS JUVENILE LEAD). Where does *she* come from? Not from the SSA list, I can tell you that.

The Leading Lady's contempt is a performance of contempt — she is covering her own disorientation by ranking the newcomer below professional standards.

PLAYER 2 (AS LEADING LADY). A vulgar trick. And not even a good one.

The Father seizes the chaos as a philosophical lecture, converting his guilt into an aesthetic argument; the longer he talks, the further he is from having to feel.

THE FATHER *[dominating the protests]*. Excuse me, all of you! Why are you so anxious to destroy, in the name of a vulgar, commonplace sense of truth, this reality which comes to birth, attracted and formed by the magic of the stage itself — which has indeed more right to live here than you, since it is much truer than you, if you don't mind my saying so? Which is the actress among you who is to play Madame Pace? Well, here is Madame Pace herself. You'll allow, I fancy, that the actress who acts her will be less true than this woman, who is herself in person.

*But the scene between the **Step-Daughter** and **Madame Pace** has already begun despite the protest of the actors and the reply of **The Father**. It has begun quietly, naturally, in a manner impossible for the stage. So when the actors, called to attention by **The Father**, turn round and see **Madame Pace**, who has placed one hand under the **Step-Daughter's** chin to raise her head, they observe her at first with great attention, but hearing her speak in an unintelligible manner their interest begins to wane.*

The Manager's doubled monosyllable is stalling — he is buying time while his authority catches up with an event he has no procedure for.

THE MANAGER. Well? well?

The Leading Man's theatrical posture (cupped ear, projecting bearing) exposes how the company can only process the uncanny through professional habit.

PLAYER 1 (AS LEADING MAN) *[cupping a hand to his ear, the bearing of a man used to being heard at the back of the house].* What does she say? Madame — speak up.

The Juvenile Lead's demand for volume is comic but also a refusal: if it is loud enough to be theatre, it is safe enough not to be real.

PLAYER 3 (AS JUVENILE LEAD). Louder! Louder please!

The Step-Daughter separates two kinds of speech — loud shameful accusation (aimed at the Father) and the soft transactional register of Pace's world; she understands both from the inside.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[leaving Madame Pace, who smiles a Sphinx-like smile, and advancing towards the actors].* Louder? Louder? What on earth are you talking about? These aren't matters one shouts at the top of one's voice. If I spoke them loud, sir, it was to *shame* him and have my revenge. *[Indicates Father.]* But for Madame it's quite a different matter.

The Manager's instruction to 'pretend to be alone' is unwittingly cruel: he is asking characters who lived that privacy to simulate it for spectators' comfort.

THE MANAGER. Indeed? indeed? But here, you know, people have got to make themselves heard, my dear. Even we who are on the stage can't hear you. What will it be when the public's in the theatre? And anyway, you can very well speak up now among yourselves, since we shan't be present to listen to you as we are now. You've got to pretend to be alone in a room at the back of a shop where no one can hear you.

The Step-Daughter, level and unhurried, makes a sign of disagreement two or three times with her finger.

The Manager's question is more alarmed than curious — a single 'no' from a character is insubordination to the whole theatrical contract he manages.

THE MANAGER. What do you mean by no?

The Step-Daughter's quiet warning reintroduces the Father as the hidden listener; the danger is not the audience but the man behind the door who already knows.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[low, no theatrics].* There's someone who will hear us if she *[Indicating Madame Pace.]* speaks out loud.

The Manager's consternation and the actors' laughter are the same defensive reflex — the laugh converts genuine dread into social noise.

THE MANAGER *[in consternation].* What? Have you got someone else to spring on us now? *[The Actors burst out laughing.]*

The Father's offer to take his place behind the door is both cooperative and self-serving: he can re-enter as the character rather than the accused man standing in the light.

THE FATHER. No, no sir. She is alluding to me. I've got to be here — there behind that door, in waiting; and Madame Pace knows it. In fact, if you will allow me, I'll go there at once, so I can be quite ready. *[Moves away.]*

The Manager appeals to theatrical conventions not to protect the scene but to reassert his own authority over a sequence he did not choreograph.

THE MANAGER *[stopping him].* No! Wait! wait! We must observe the conventions of the theatre. Before you are ready...

The Step-Daughter's urgency is not artistic enthusiasm; she is hunting the moment of exposure and fears any delay will allow the Father — or the Manager — to soften it.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[interrupting him].* No, get on with it at once! I'm just dying, I tell you, to act this scene. If he's ready, I'm more than ready.

The Manager insists on the Pace scene first as a director's procedure, unaware he is asking her to rehearse the prelude to her own degradation on demand.

THE MANAGER *[shouting].* But, my dear young lady, first of all, we must have the scene between you and this lady... *[Indicates Madame Pace.]* Do you understand?...

The Step-Daughter's summary is clipped and matter-of-fact, draining the scene of sentiment — she has rehearsed this story so many times it has become inventory.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Good Heavens! She's been telling me what you know already: that my mother's work is badly done again, that the material's ruined; and that if I want her to continue to help us in our misery I must be patient...

Madame Pace's elaborate self-introduction is a performance of respectability that names its own corruption: the ledger-logic ('the book, she balance') is the horror dressed as bookkeeping.

MADAME PACE *[coming forward with an air of great importance, hand pressed to her chest, very pleased indeed to be here].* Good morning, good morning, sir! Here I am, here I am — so sorry I am late, so sorry — the traffic, the trams in this town, always the same. *[A small bow to the room; the silver chain at her waist swings once.]* Madame Pace, sir — dresses and coats, off the rue de Bourg, the courtyard near Saint-François. You know me. All Lausanne, it know me. Forty years. Forty years in this canton, sir, and never one bad word about Pace. *[Smiling, the smile of a hostess at her own front door.]* I no wanta be hard, eh? I no wanta take advantage. I am a good woman, sir. *[The smile, unchanged.]* Only — the lady over there, she ruin the silk. Again. The third time this month, sir — the third time. Silk, sir, you no pay with the tears. Somebody must pay. The mother, she pay with the hands — or the little one, she pay. *[The smile, unchanged.]* Either way, sir — the book, she balance. Pace, she always balance the book.

Note. Madame Pace speaks in a heavy accent, not in another language — an Italian-Swiss woman who has lived in French Lausanne too long and not long enough. The foreignness lives in the music of the voice and the broken grammar; the page keeps the words plain and lets the actor carry the sound. Played for full comedy on her arrival; played for full chill by her exit. The audience must laugh at her first line. They must regret laughing by her last.

The Manager's alarm is comic but genuine: Pace's accent reduces operatic villainy to something petty and mercantile, which is somehow worse than a melodrama villain.

THE MANAGER *[alarmed].* What? What? She talks like that? *[The Actors burst out laughing again.]*

The Step-Daughter laughs with the actors, but her laughter is knowing and a little cruel — she finds the accent funny precisely because it made her own degradation sound ridiculous.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[also laughing].* Yes yes, that's the way she talks — that accent of hers! Most comical it is!

Madame Pace's rebuttal — the bells of Saint-François, the regularity of Wednesdays and Fridays — reveals that her trade is built on the same civic rhythm as churchgoing.

MADAME PACE. It seem not very polite, gentlemen, to laugh at me — when I try to speak proper for the customers. My customers — eh — they no laugh, sir. They come back. Wednesday afternoon. Friday afternoon. Sometimes the Sunday, after the church. *[A small shrug, the smile.]* Like the bells of Saint-François. You hear those bells, sir, in this town? Three time a week. *Bom. Bom. Bom.*

The Manager's delight at 'comic relief' is a professional misreading so spectacular it becomes its own indictment: he is aestheticising exploitation.

THE MANAGER. Perfect! Of course! Of course! Let her talk like that! Just what we want. Talk just like that, Madame, if you please! The effect's guaranteed — exactly what we needed, a bit of comic relief to lift all this gloom. Of course she talks like that! Magnificent!

The Step-Daughter reclaims the laugh as a weapon: she shows how Pace's ledger-language makes violation sound like commerce, and how that very absurdity is what makes it bearable to the men who paid.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Magnificent? Certainly! When such things are said to a girl in language of that kind, the effect is certain, since it seems almost a joke. One feels inclined to laugh when one hears her recite her inventory of clients — clean ones, polite ones, paying ones — as if she were counting bolts of silk. Nice old gentleman, eh, Madame?

Madame Pace's portrait of the 'polite' client is the most chilling speech in the scene — she describes the erasure of the girl's name and face with the serenity of a satisfied hostess.

MADAME PACE. Not so old, my dear. Not so old. Forty-five, maybe fifty — the age when a man have money in the pocket and shame in the throat, eh, sir? The best age, my dear, in my long experience. He clean. He polite. *[The smile, unchanged.]* He pay cash. The blue envelope on the little mahogany table, you no even gotta look at his face, you no even gotta count. The polite ones, sir — they count for you. He no ask your name. He no need to. He call you little one, he call you dear, he call you whatever please him — for that little while the name belong to him. *[The smile.]* And if you no like him? Eh — no scandal. Nobody talk. It stay quiet, like everything in this town. Like the silk. Like the sewing. Like everything that get ruin in Pace's shop. The lady know. The lady stay quiet too.

The Mother's eruption is years of self-silencing finally outrunning her body — the Wednesday tea, the knowledge half-held, the deliberate not-seeing are all confessed in the same breath as the accusation.

THE MOTHER *[jumping up amid the amazement and consternation of the actors who had not been noticing her. They move to restrain her — and the voice that comes out of her is the one she has not used for years, and once it starts it comes out faster than her body can carry it].* You old devil! You murderess! *[Trembling, but the voice does not stop.]* Three years you took her from me. Three years. I sat at your kitchen table with the needle in my hand, and the tea you served me — your kind tea, your terrible kind tea — and somewhere I knew. Somewhere, in the back of my head, I half-knew. But if I let myself know it, the children at home did not eat. So I drank the tea. I drank your tea, madame, every Wednesday, every Friday, sometimes the Sunday — and I did not let myself see that my own daughter was just down the corridor in your back room. *[Her hand, briefly, at her own chest.]* May God forgive me. May God forgive me. I drank the tea.

The Step-Daughter's rush to calm her mother carries a flicker of fear: the raw voice she hears is the wound beneath the weapon, and it threatens to undo the cold control she has built.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[running over to calm her Mother — and a little frightened, perhaps, by the voice she has just heard come out of her].* Calm yourself, Mother, calm yourself! Please don't...

The Mother's return to the smile — Pace's 'kindness' — reveals the deepest injury: she believed she had found a friend in her isolation, and that belief was the mechanism of her daughter's exploitation.

THE MOTHER *[she cannot quite stop yet; the voice has been waiting too long].* And the smile, devil. The smile you had for me when I came into the kitchen with the finished sewing. I thought it was a kindness. I thought you were the only person in Lausanne with a kindness in her for a poor widow from another town. May God forgive me — I thought it was a kindness.

The Father's urge to calm the Mother is as much about composure management as compassion; the scene is threatening to exceed the version of events he has prepared to argue.

THE FATHER *[going to her also, at the same time, the body now beginning to give him away too].* Calm yourself! Don't get excited! Sit down now!

The Mother's curt final demand — after the torrent — shows the collapse back into suppression; she has spent what she had, and now only wants the source of the memory removed.

THE MOTHER *[the voice short again now, as if she has spent what she had].* Well then. Take that woman out of my sight.

The Step-Daughter's statement to the Manager is both practical and protective; she is also quietly preventing the Mother's pain from being absorbed into theatrical spectacle.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[to Manager].* It is impossible for my mother to remain here.

The Father's logical explanation conceals the real motive; the Mother's presence exposes a guilt that his careful philosophical framing cannot survive.

THE FATHER *[to Manager].* They can't be here together. And here's why: that woman wasn't with us when we came. If they are on together, the whole thing is given away. Inevitably. As you see.

The Manager's 'first rough sketch' language is a procedural retreat — he domesticates the eruption into a staging problem so he can feel in charge again.

THE MANAGER. It doesn't matter. This is only a first rough sketch — just to get an idea of the various points of the scene, even confusedly... *[Turning to the **Mother** and leading her to her chair.]* Come along, my dear lady, sit down now, and let's get on with the scene...

*Meanwhile, the **Step-Daughter**, coming forward again, turns to **Madame Pace**.*

The Step-Daughter's crisp command to Madame Pace is a stage direction issued by a character — she is now directing the scene she is also living inside.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Come on, Madame, come on!

Madame Pace's house-rule speech is a grotesque pastoral: the hen-and-chicken metaphor makes the exploitation of girls sound like prudent animal husbandry.

MADAME PACE *[offended, but not loud — the offense of a businesswoman whose house rules have been questioned].* Eh no, thank you. The mother present — it is not possible, sir. It is against the rule. I have my method. I have had my method for forty years. The mother she stay in the kitchen with the tea, like always. The little one she come down the corridor when Pace she ring the little bell. *[Lifts a hand, as if to a small invisible bell.]* The business it no close while the mother she watch. The chickens too, sir. Even the chickens — you no kill them where the hen can see. The hen, she scream. The hen, she ruin the meat. It is a rule of the house. House rule. Pace, she keep the house rules.

The Step-Daughter's imperious dismissal of Madame Pace is the one moment she exercises power — by ejecting the procuress she stages herself as the agent, not the commodity.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Nonsense! Bring on this *old gentleman* who wants to talk so nicely to me. *[Addressing the **Company** imperiously.]* We've got to do this scene one way or another, haven't we? Come on! *[To **Madame Pace**.]* You can go!

Madame Pace's exit speech is a contract renewal in disguise: she names the debt, the hunger, the next silk — ensuring the Step-Daughter leaves still owing, still findable.

MADAME PACE *[adjusting the silver chain at her waist; the scissors swing once].* Yes yes, of course. I go. I go. But my dear — you remember. Without Pace, nothing. You still in the school with your braids and your stomach empty, your little sister at home crying for the bread that is not in the house. You owe it all to me. To Pace. *[Pauses at the door. The smile returned, calm now, almost tender.]* And when the lady ruin the next silk — and she will, my dear, she always do — you know where to find me. *[Beat. The voice softer, the smile unchanged.]* There is always the next silk, my dear. There is always the debt. There is always Pace. *[The scissors swing once more at her waist.]* Don't you forget the name. *[Exits. Not furious. Unhurried.]*

The Step-Daughter directing the Father's entrance — correcting his posture, cueing his line — is a controlled revenge: she stages him as the man he was so the stage can convict him.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[to the **Father**].* Now you make your entry. No, you needn't go over here. Come here. Let's suppose you've already come in. Like that, yes! I'm here with my head bowed, modest-like. Come on! Out with your voice! Say "Good morning, Miss" in that peculiar tone, that special tone...

The Manager's assertion of authority is the comedy of two directors in one room; but his instruction to the Father is also an admission that he cannot resist seeing the scene played out.

THE MANAGER. Excuse me, but are you the Manager, or am I? *[To the **Father**, who looks undecided and perplexed.]* Get on with it, man! Go down there to the back of the stage. You needn't go off. Then come right forward here.

*The **Father** does as he is told, looking troubled and perplexed at first. But as soon as he begins to move, the reality of the action affects him, and he begins to smile and to be more natural. The **Actors** watch intently.*

The Manager's whispered 'ready?' to the Prompter shows the machinery of theatre swallowing a live wound: the scene is already being turned into a text to be recorded.

THE MANAGER *[sotto voce, quickly to the **Prompter** in his box].* Ready! ready? Get ready to write now.

The Father's composed 'Good afternoon' is the mask of the seducer performing normalcy — composure is the character's technique, and the actor inside him knows it.

THE FATHER *[coming forward, composed now — this is the scene, this is the man he was, that man did not show what he was feeling].* Good afternoon, Miss.

The Step-Daughter's return greeting contains a lifetime of revulsion held behind a single decorous phrase — the bow is the posture of submission, the disgust is the truth beneath it.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[head bowed down slightly, with restrained disgust].* Good afternoon!

The Father's stammering realisation that she is very young is not conscience — it is the calculation of risk, dressed briefly in the clothes of surprise.

THE FATHER *[looks under her hat which partly covers her face. Perceiving she is very young, he makes an exclamation, partly of surprise, partly of fear lest he compromise himself in a risky adventure].* Ah... but... ah... I say... this isn't the first time you've come here, is it?

The Step-Daughter's bare 'No sir' is the most devastating possible answer: two syllables that confirm she has been here before and has run out of the energy to pretend otherwise.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[the rehearsed bow — no softness in it].* No sir.

The Father's escalating questions — once, more than once — are not curiosity; they are a man reassuring himself that prior visits have established a precedent that removes his responsibility.

THE FATHER. You've been here before, eh? *[Then seeing her nod agreement.]* More than once? *[Waits for her to answer, looks under her hat, smiles, and then says.]* Well then, there's no need to be so shy, is there? May I take off your hat?

The Step-Daughter forestalls him on the hat because she will not be touched before she chooses to be — removing it herself is the last act of self-possession available to her.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[anticipating him and with veiled disgust].* No sir... I'll do it myself. *[Takes it off quickly.]*

*The **Mother**, who watches the progress of the scene with **The Son** beside her, the Child-bundle held tight in her arms and the Boy-chair pulled in against her knee, is on thorns; and follows with varying expressions of sorrow, indignation, anxiety, and horror the words and actions of the other two. From time to time she hides her face in her hands and sobs.*

The Mother's prayer, muffled behind her hands, is not theatrical; it is the sound of a parent for whom witnessing is indistinguishable from complicity.

THE MOTHER *[without lifting her head from her hands].* Oh, my God. My God.

The Father's offer of a smarter hat is the transaction dressed as gallantry — the gift is the price, and he delivers it with the fluency of a man who has done this before.

THE FATHER *[playing his part with a touch of gallantry].* Give it to me! I'll put it down. *[Takes hat from her hands.]* But a dear little head like yours should have a smarter hat. Come and help me choose one from the stock, won't you?

The Leading Man's interruption about the company's hats is a purely professional anxiety that, by its absurd timing, accidentally names the commodification happening on stage.

PLAYER 1 (AS L'INGÉNUE) *[interrupting — protective of the company's property, the senior actor surfacing through the wig].* I say... those are our hats, you know.

The Manager's furious silence-call reveals his own captivation — he wants the scene to continue more than he wants decorum restored, so he protects it from interruption.

THE MANAGER *[furious].* Silence! silence! Don't try and be funny, if you please... We're playing the scene now I'd have you notice. *[To the **Step-Daughter**.]* Begin again, please!

The Step-Daughter's quiet refusal of the hat mid-scene is not a line — it is a character who has already decided where this ends, holding her position.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[continuing].* No thank you, sir.

The Father's insistence — 'Madame will be pleased, she expects it' — shows the triangulation of the transaction: Pace is the silent partner whose approval lubricates the exchange.

THE FATHER. Oh, come now. Don't talk like that. You must take it. I'll be upset if you don't. There are some lovely little hats here; and then — Madame will be pleased. She expects it, anyway, you know.

The Step-Daughter's 'I couldn't wear it' is the first hint of the black dress to come — a refusal that carries its real reason just below the surface.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. No, no! I couldn't wear it!

The Father's breezy 'there's always a way round' is the seducer's all-purpose solvent: he frames every obstacle as a social inconvenience, not a moral one.

THE FATHER. Oh, you're thinking about what they'd say at home if they saw you come in with a new hat? My dear girl, there's always a way round these little matters, you know.

The Step-Daughter touching the black dress once is the wound surfacing through the transaction — mourning enters the scene as a single restrained gesture that changes everything.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER [*level, not pleading*]. No, it's not that. I couldn't wear it because I am — as you see — you might have noticed. [*Touches the front of her black dress, once.*]

The Father's pause before 'in mourning' is the play's most nakedly theatrical moment of ethical failure: the audience watches a man choose a polished apology over an honest reckoning.

THE FATHER [*a beat — the smallest pause. He did not, in fact, say "I'm frightfully sorry." He said something else. The audience must see the lie being made in real time.*]. ... in mourning. Of course. I beg your pardon. I'm — I'm frightfully sorry...

She performs graciousness as a survival tactic, swallowing disgust to regain control of the scene before the Father can shape its meaning.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER [*forcing herself to conquer her indignation and nausea*]. Stop! Stop! It's I who must thank you. There's no need for you to feel mortified or specially sorry. Don't think any more of what I've said. [*Tries to smile.*] I must forget that I am dressed so...

He cuts the record to protect theatrical tidiness, treating the Characters' pain as raw material to be edited rather than truth to be witnessed.

THE MANAGER [*interrupting and turning to the Prompter*]. Stop a minute! Stop! Don't write that down. Cut out that last bit. [*Then to the Father and Step-Daughter.*] Fine! it's going fine! [*To the Father only.*] And now you can go on as we arranged. [*To the Actors.*] Pretty good that scene, where he offers her the hat, eh?

Her impatience is hunger — she wants the seduction scene exposed, the degradation played in full before anyone can dilute it.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. The best's coming now. Why can't we go on?

His instruction to treat it lightly reveals the theatre's instinct to aestheticise trauma, turning wound into entertainment at a safe, palatable distance.

THE MANAGER. Have a little patience! [*To the Actors.*] Of course, it must be treated rather lightly.

The Leading Man's vanity inflates to fill any dramatic gap; his confidence is costume, performing competence he hasn't earned in this alien reality.

PLAYER 1 (AS LEADING MAN). Still — with a bit of go in it. Which I, of course, will provide.

PART III — THE SUBSTITUTION

The Leading Lady's breezy confidence signals professional detachment — this is craft, not feeling; she has no stake in the scene's real wound.

PLAYER 2 (AS LEADING LADY) [*the diva fully present; she has done a thousand scenes harder than this*]. Of course. It's easy enough. [*To Leading Man.*] Shall you and I try it now?

His immediate readiness exposes theatrical vanity: the Leading Man is eager to perform, indifferent to what the scene actually cost the originals.

PLAYER 1 (AS LEADING MAN). Why, yes! I'll prepare my entrance. [*Exit to make his entrance.*]

The Manager's logistics-driven interruption reveals how completely the machinery of theatre has consumed the Characters' living experience.

THE MANAGER *[to Leading Lady]*. See here! The scene between you and Madame Pace is finished. I'll have it written out properly after. You remain here... oh, where are you going?

A trivial prop adjustment; the Leading Lady reasserts her diva prerogative, reclaiming control of her image before surrendering to someone else's story.

PLAYER 2 (AS LEADING LADY). One minute. I want to put my hat on again. *[Goes over to hat-rack and puts her hat on her head.]*

The Manager reduces the Step-Daughter's anguish to a stage direction — bowed head as costume note, grief made into blocking.

THE MANAGER. Good! You stay here with your head bowed down a bit.

The Step-Daughter's flat, factual objection is also an act of possession: she will not let a wrong body carry her grief without protest.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. But she isn't dressed in black.

The Leading Lady's competitive vanity — "more effectively" — exposes how theatre turns trauma into a professional challenge to be won.

PLAYER 2 (AS LEADING LADY) *[an appraising look, head tilted, eyes narrowed]*. But I shall be. And much more effectively than you.

The Manager's clapping hands enforce theatrical momentum over emotional truth; his instruction to "learn something" is an insult dressed as pedagogy.

THE MANAGER *[to Step-Daughter]*. Be quiet please, and watch! You'll be able to learn something. *[Clapping his hands.]* Come on! come on! Entrance, please! *[The door at rear of stage opens, and the Leading Man enters with the lively manner of an old gallant. The rendering of the scene by the Actors from the very first words is seen to be quite a different thing, though it has not in any way the air of a parody. Naturally, the Step-Daughter and the Father, not being able to recognize themselves in the Leading Lady and the Leading Man, who deliver their words in different tones and with a different psychology, express, sometimes with smiles, sometimes with gestures, the impression they receive.]*

The Leading Man's generic greeting flattens the charged original moment; without the Father's guilt-laden gaze, the scene is already a different event.

PLAYER 1 (AS LEADING MAN). Good afternoon, Miss...

The Father's two-word eruption reveals how physically unbearable it is to watch his own memory mis-embodied; his control collapses instantly.

THE FATHER *[at once unable to contain himself]*. No! no!

The Step-Daughter noticing the way the Leading Man enters, bursts out laughing.

The Manager's fury is directed equally at laughter and protest — both threaten the production's momentum, both feel to him like sabotage.

THE MANAGER *[furious]*. Silence! And you please just stop that laughing. If we go on like this, we'll never finish.

The Step-Daughter weaponises her laughter: she proves through her own body that the imitation is false, turning her contempt into theatrical evidence.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Forgive me, sir, but it's natural enough. This lady *[Indicating Leading Lady.]* stands there still; but if she is supposed to be me, I can assure you that if I heard anyone say "Good afternoon" in that manner and in that tone, I would burst out laughing — exactly as I did.

The Father's partial agreement is not concession but reclamation — he reaches for the details that define his version of events, his truth.

THE FATHER. Yes, yes, the manner, the tone...

The Manager dismisses the Characters' testimony as noise; "Rubbish" reveals his priority is the scene's theatrical shape, not its lived accuracy.

THE MANAGER. Nonsense! Rubbish! Stand aside and let me see the action.

The Leading Man's professional quibble about blocking is comic self-importance, but it also exposes how utterly disconnected he is from the scene's moral weight.

PLAYER 1 (AS LEADING MAN) *[the practised gallantry already in his shoulders before he speaks]*. If I've got to play an old man walking into a place of — shall we say — *equivocal character*, and we all know what we mean, then at the very least let me find the door.

The Manager's blind encouragement — "it goes fine" — marks the precise moment his authority becomes self-deception; he cannot see what the Characters see.

THE MANAGER. Don't listen to them, for Heaven's sake! Do it again! It goes fine. *[Waiting for the Actors to begin again.]* Well?

Bare repetition of the greeting; without stage direction, the hollowness of the imitation is laid bare, the words stripped of any felt content.

PLAYER 1 (AS LEADING MAN). Good afternoon, Miss.

Three words, perfectly calibrated to be polite and empty; the Leading Lady's "Good afternoon" carries none of the Step-Daughter's compelled, shamed compliance.

PLAYER 2 (AS LEADING LADY). Good afternoon.

The Leading Man performs recognition and fear as learned technical beats; beside the Father's original guilt, it reads as theatrical shorthand.

PLAYER 1 (AS LEADING MAN) *[imitating the gesture of the Father when he looked under the hat, and then expressing quite clearly first satisfaction and then fear]*. Ah, but... I say... this is not the first time that you have come here, is it?

The Manager steps in to act the scene himself, revealing his controlling need to shape reality — he cannot resist becoming a character too.

THE MANAGER. Good — but not so heavily. *[Acts it himself.]* And you say: "No, sir."

A single, obedient line; the Leading Lady's "No, sir" is technically correct and emotionally inert, exposing the gap between compliance and lived submission.

PLAYER 2 (AS LEADING LADY). No, sir.

The Leading Man delivers the line as a knowing gallant's gambit; the Father's version held something darker — knowledge that implicated him, not her.

PLAYER 1 (AS LEADING MAN). You've been here before, more than once.

The Manager choreographs disgust as if it were a traffic signal; reducing the Step-Daughter's involuntary shame to a rehearsable head movement.

THE MANAGER. No, no, stop! Let her nod "yes" first. "You've been here before, eh?" *[The Leading Lady lifts up her head slightly and closes her eyes as though in disgust. Then she inclines her head twice.]*

The Step-Daughter's suppressed laugh is not amusement but horror; the parody of her worst moment breaks through as uncontrollable, anguished release.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[unable to contain herself]*. Oh my God! *[Puts a hand to her mouth to prevent herself from laughing.]*

The Manager's oblivious question reveals his complete inability to perceive the emotional reality happening in plain sight beside his rehearsal.

THE MANAGER *[turning round]*. What's the matter?

The denial is self-protective; the Step-Daughter retreats, calculating that explanation is useless — the Manager will never understand what he has just witnessed.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Nothing, nothing!

Two words of theatrical authority; the Manager's impatience overrides any human pause, insisting the scene's machinery never stop for feeling.

THE MANAGER *[to Leading Man]*. Go on!

The Leading Man's hat line carries a practiced seducer's lightness; the Father's version carried the weight of a man who knows exactly where this leads.

PLAYER 1 (AS LEADING MAN). You've been here before, eh? Well then, there's no need to be so shy, is there? May I take off your hat?

The **Leading Man** says this last speech in such a tone and with such gestures that the **Step-Daughter**, hand pressed to her mouth, struggles to keep from laughing aloud.

The Manager's urgent whispered command reveals his own anxiety — he knows the scene is fragile and is holding it together through sheer willpower.

THE MANAGER [low, firm, to the players]. Don't stop. Don't stop. We're past the worst of it. Carry on!

The Leading Lady performs autonomy with a smooth professional gesture; the Step-Daughter's original act would have been trembling, deliberate, utterly different.

PLAYER 2 (AS LEADING LADY) [recovering, back into the rehearsed register]. No sir... I'll do it myself. [Removes her hat with the efficient gesture of a woman who has done it a hundred times in front of a mirror.]

The Leading Man's hat-and-compliment line is stagecraft — flattery as a well-oiled key; what the Father felt in that moment was something far more ambivalent.

PLAYER 1 (AS LEADING MAN) [a step closer, practised gallantry]. Allow me — I'll put it down for you. But a dear little head like yours should have a smarter hat. Come and help me choose one from the stock, won't you?

Politely demure on cue: the Leading Lady's refusal is a scripted beat, not the Step-Daughter's mixture of need and self-disgust.

PLAYER 2 (AS LEADING LADY) [politely demure]. No thank you, sir.

The Leading Man's light insistence reads as charming theatre; the Father's original pressure came from a different, more compromised place entirely.

PLAYER 1 (AS LEADING MAN) [the smile he has used a thousand times]. Oh come now — you must take it. I'll be upset if you don't. There's always a way round these little matters, you know.

The mourning revelation, delivered on cue with a practised gesture, becomes an actress hitting her mark rather than a girl exposing a wound.

PLAYER 2 (AS LEADING LADY) [eyes downcast, on cue]. It's not the hat, sir. I couldn't wear it because I am — as you see — you might have noticed. [Touches the front of her dress with the back of her hand.]

Gallantry performed to order; the Father's original "I beg your pardon" came out of genuine, complicated shame — the Leading Man produces only courtesy.

PLAYER 1 (AS LEADING MAN) [a beat, then deeply gallant]. ...in mourning. Of course. I beg your pardon. I'm frightfully sorry.

A short, theatrical pause. The **Father** turns his face away. The **Step-Daughter** is no longer struggling not to laugh — she is staring.

The Leading Lady executes the emotional recovery exactly where directed; the precision of "exactly where she has been taught" makes the falseness visible.

PLAYER 2 (AS LEADING LADY) [the rehearsed recovery, voice catching exactly where she has been taught it should catch]. It's I who must thank you. There's no need for you to feel mortified or specially sorry. Don't think any more of what I've said. I must forget that I am dressed so...

The Manager's satisfied note-taking treats the Characters' living memory as raw material to be efficiently processed and filed.

THE MANAGER [satisfied, to the **Prompter**]. Good. Good. Get that down. We'll skip the back-and-forth on the mourning — straight through to the next beat.

A tiny, devastating correction: the Step-Daughter's "He didn't say" marks the line where theatrical approximation becomes a lie about what actually happened.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER [low, almost to herself]. He didn't say "I'm frightfully sorry."

The Manager's dismissal reveals his fundamental misunderstanding — to him, the words are interchangeable; to her, every syllable is scarred into memory.

THE MANAGER. We've done that bit. Move on.

"His hand stayed on the hat" — the Step-Daughter restores the physical detail the theatre erased; the body's stillness carried the scene's real meaning.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. He said "Oh." And then he didn't move. His hand stayed on the hat.

The Father's quiet corroboration is not defence but witness; for once he and the Step-Daughter share the same memory, briefly, painfully united.

THE FATHER *[turning back, quietly]*. Yes. He said "Oh."

The Leading Lady's professional ultimatum makes explicit the incompatibility: the Characters' presence doesn't enrich the scene — it dissolves the fiction.

PLAYER 2 (AS LEADING LADY) *[breaking character, to **Manager**]*. Sir, I cannot work with the originals standing five feet away correcting every breath. Either they sit or I sit.

The Manager's tired acquiescence shows authority draining away; he is managing a situation he no longer controls, just trying to keep the scene alive.

THE MANAGER *[tired]*. They will sit down.

The Step-Daughter's refusal is not defiance for its own sake — sitting down would be surrendering the only ground she still holds in this theatre.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[hard, decisive]*. We will not.

The Leading Lady's wounded-diva exit threat is also an unintended truth: her dignity is professional, not personal — she can afford to leave.

PLAYER 2 (AS LEADING LADY) *[the veteran has had enough — the diva's posture goes from offended to leaving]*. I am not going to stand here being made a fool of by that woman. I have been made a fool of — believe me — by considerably better.

The Leading Man's calculated pause before "I am through" reveals the actor weighing consequences; his exit is a decision, not an emotion.

PLAYER 1 (AS LEADING MAN) *[two steps toward the exit — then a calculation crosses his face; he stops]*. Neither am I. I am through with this scene.

The Manager's "for once and all" betrays exhaustion — he is no longer directing a play, he is refereeing a collision he cannot stop.

THE MANAGER *[shouting to **Step-Daughter**]*. Silence! for once and all, I tell you!

The Step-Daughter's doubled plea is surprising precisely because it is uncharacteristic; beneath the contempt lives a creature who still wants to be seen.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Forgive me! forgive me!

The Manager's scolding is entirely about social form; he cannot name what is really happening, so he calls it bad manners.

THE MANAGER. You haven't any manners: that's what it is! You go too far.

The Father's instinct to intercede for the Step-Daughter is an ambiguous gesture — protection or control, genuine care or image management.

THE FATHER *[endeavouring to intervene]*. Yes, it's true, but excuse her...

"Absolutely disgusting" — the Manager aestheticises his discomfort; the word belongs to a world of propriety that has no language for what the Characters carry.

THE MANAGER. Excuse what? It's absolutely disgusting.

The Father reaches for "strange" because he cannot say true; the scene's wrongness is not theatrical failure but ontological — it is not them.

THE FATHER. Yes, sir, but believe me, it has such a strange effect when...

The Manager's triple question — "Strange? Why strange? Where is it strange?" — reveals defensive incomprehension; he feels accused but cannot identify the charge.

THE MANAGER. Strange? Why strange? Where is it strange?

The Father's admission that the actors are "not us" is the play's central philosophical wound stated plainly — imitation and identity cannot coincide.

THE FATHER. No, sir; I admire your actors — this gentleman here, this lady; but they are certainly not us!

The Manager's "I should hope not" is a logical defence and an unwitting confession that theatre is structurally unable to deliver what the Characters need.

THE MANAGER. I should hope not. Evidently they cannot be you, if they are actors.

"They want to be us and they aren't" — the Father articulates the unbridgeable gap: theatre promises presence and delivers representation, always falling short.

THE FATHER. Just so: actors! They act our parts exceedingly well — but it produces quite a different effect on us. They want to be us, and they aren't.

The Manager's "What is it, then?" is not curiosity but exasperation; he asks because he has run out of technical solutions, not because he seeks truth.

THE MANAGER. What is it, then?

The Father's trailing sentence — "theirs... no longer ours" — locates the horror: the Characters have watched their own lives become someone else's property.

THE FATHER. Something that is... that is theirs — and no longer ours...

The Manager reasserts institutional authority, brushing off the Father's protest by invoking his earlier ruling — a reflex of professional control masking unease.

THE MANAGER. But naturally, inevitably. I've told you so already.

The Father's repeated 'I understand' is capitulation dressed as comprehension; he retreats into compliance, buying time to regroup.

THE FATHER. Yes, I understand... I understand...

The Manager expels the author-figure to restore his directorial dominance; his irritation at authors reveals the theatre's deep discomfort with the originating voice.

THE MANAGER. Well then, let's have no more of it! *[Turning to the Actors.]* We'll have the rehearsals by ourselves, afterwards, in the ordinary way. I never could stand rehearsing with the author present. He's never satisfied! *[Turning to Father and Step-Daughter.]* Come on! Let's get on with it again; and try and see if you can't keep from laughing.

The Step-Daughter's ominous calm signals she has stopped resisting and started anticipating the moment that will expose the Father — her stillness is predatory.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Oh, I shan't laugh any more. There's a nice little bit coming for me now: you'll see.

The Manager tidies the scene into theatrical shorthand, reducing the degrading negotiation to a cue-and-question; his stage directions are an act of sanitisation.

THE MANAGER. Well then: when she says "Don't think any more of what I've said. I must forget, etc.," you *[Addressing the Father.]* come in sharp with "I understand, I understand"; and then you ask her...

Her single-word interruption is a trap being sprung — she wants him to name exactly what the Father asked, forcing it into the open on the record.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[interrupting]*. What?

The Manager answers innocently, unaware the mourning question is the fuse; he is directing toward the explosion without knowing it.

THE MANAGER. Why she is in mourning.

She replaces the Manager's genteel blocking with the actual words spoken in Madame Pace's room — 'let's take this little dress off' — weaponising verbatim memory.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Not at all! See here, sir — when I told him it was useless for me to think about wearing mourning, do you know what he said? "Ah well," he said, "then let's take this little dress off."

The Manager's excitement is purely theatrical; 'riot in the theatre' means a hit, revealing he values sensation over the human reality he is staging.

THE MANAGER. Great! Just what we want, to make a riot in the theatre!

Her one-line defence strips the debate to its core: she is the custodian of what really happened and will not allow fiction to overwrite it.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. But it's the truth!

The Manager openly admits truth has a box-office ceiling — a candid confession that the stage is fundamentally a negotiation between fact and palatability.

THE MANAGER. What does that matter? Acting is our business here. Truth up to a certain point, but no further.

Her question is not genuine enquiry; it is an invitation for him to show his hand so she can refuse it, maintaining her position as truth's guardian.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. What do you want to do then?

The Manager's evasion — 'leave it to me' — is the director's classic power-move, promising resolution while withholding it to keep the characters compliant.

THE MANAGER. You'll see, you'll see! Leave it to me.

The Step-Daughter performs a savage précis of the sentimental version the Manager would stage, mocking its falsity and insisting on the childhood detail as the true horror.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. No, sir. What you want is a little *romantic sentimental* scene pieced together out of my disgust — out of every cruel and vile reason I am what I am. He is to ask me why I wear mourning; I am to answer, with tears in my eyes, that it is just two months since papa died. No, sir. No. He has to say to me — as he did say, the way one speaks to a child — *well, let's take this little dress off.*

His hands-through-hair gesture betrays real disturbance; for once the theatre professional is not managing the content but genuinely rattled by it.

THE MANAGER *[running his hands through his hair]*. For Heaven's sake! What are you saying?

Dropping the pretence of performance, she names what she is doing with stark repetition — insisting the bare fact must stand regardless of theatrical convention.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[no longer playing]*. The truth. The truth.

The Manager concedes her horror privately while denying it publicly; his 'it won't go' is commercial self-interest disguised as aesthetic judgement.

THE MANAGER. It may be. I don't deny it, and I can understand all your horror; but you must surely see that you can't have this kind of thing on the stage. It won't go.

Her threat to leave is not a negotiating gambit but a genuine assertion of self-respect — she would rather have no stage than a falsified one.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Not possible, eh? Very well! I'm much obliged to you — but I'm off!

The Manager's plea for calm reveals he now needs her; the power dynamic has silently shifted and he is playing catch-up.

THE MANAGER. Now be reasonable! Don't lose your temper!

She accuses the Manager and Father of a back-room deal, articulating with precision the difference between his guilt-as-philosophy and her experience-as-wound.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. I won't stay here. I will not. I can see you've fixed it all up with him in your office. All this talk about what is *possible* on the stage — I understand. He wants his complicated head-drama. His guilt. His torments. All performed in good taste. But I want to act my part. *My part.*

The Manager lectures on dramatic economy, but his 'neat little framework' exposes theatre's formal violence against lives that exceed its containers; his softening is strategic.

THE MANAGER *[annoyed, shaking his shoulders]*. Ah! Just your part! But there are other parts than yours — his *[Indicating the Father.]* and hers *[Indicating the Mother.]*. On the stage you can't have one character overshadowing all the others. The thing is to pack them into a neat little framework and act what isactable. From your point of view, every character would tell the public all his troubles in a nice monologue. *[softening, sitting on the edge of the table]* You must restrain yourself, my dear — in your own interest, too — because this fury of yours may make a bad impression.

Head lowered, she concedes his point in form while refusing it in substance — the other characters exist for her only as extensions of the Father's guilt.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[head lowered, not yielding]*. It's true. But remember those others mean *him* for me all the same.

The Manager's genuine puzzlement shows he has been thinking in roles, not in relational chains; her logic of inherited ruin is outside his dramaturgical vocabulary.

THE MANAGER [not understanding]. What? The others? What do you mean?

She articulates a moral genealogy: the first violation contaminates everything downstream, making the Father culpable even before her birth — a philosophical indictment, not self-pity.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. For a woman who has gone wrong, sir, the man responsible for the first fault is responsible for everything that follows. He is responsible for *all* my faults — was responsible, before I was even born. Look at him, sir. See if it isn't true.

The Manager tries to convert moral accountability into dramatic action — 'give him a chance to act it' — reducing her accusation to a cue in someone else's scene.

THE MANAGER. Well, well! And does the weight of so much responsibility seem nothing to you? Give him a chance to act it, to get it over!

Her rhetorical question dismantles the Manager's plan to spare the Father the worst moment: the child coming out of school is the detail that makes guilt irrefutable, and she is moved by her own memory.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. How? How can he act his *noble guilt*, his *moral suffering*, if you want to spare him the horror of being discovered one day — after he had asked her what he asked her — in the arms of her, that already fallen woman, that *child*, sir — the child he used to watch come out of school? *[She is moved.] [The Mother at this point is overcome with emotion, and breaks out into a fit of crying. All are touched. A long pause.]*

After the Mother's breakdown, the Step-Daughter pivots to cold strategy, offering the Manager what he wants while setting the terms that will strip away his comfortable version.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER [as soon as the **Mother** becomes a little quieter, adds resolutely and gravely]. At present, we are unknown to the public. Tomorrow, you will act us as you wish, treating us in your own manner. But do you really want to see drama, do you want to see it flash out as it really did?

The Manager's eager agreement exposes his instrumentalism — 'as much of it as is possible' — he will harvest the truth only to the depth that serves the production.

THE MANAGER. Of course! That's just what I do want, so I can use as much of it as is possible.

Asking the Mother to leave is the Step-Daughter's cruelest editorial act: she intends to replay the scene that broke their family without any witness who could stop it.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Well then, ask that Mother there to leave us.

The Mother's cry erupts from passive suffering into active refusal — the only moment she actively intervenes, making audible the pain she normally absorbs in silence.

THE MOTHER [changing her low plaint into a sharp cry]. No! No! Don't permit it, sir, don't permit it!

The Manager's 'only to try it' trivialises a reenactment the Mother experiences as happening now — his theatrical bracketing of 'rehearsal' is meaningless to her.

THE MANAGER. But it's only to try it.

Speaking to the children rather than the room, the Mother signals her suffering is not performed for the Manager's benefit; she inhabits a temporality of perpetual present.

THE MOTHER [to the Child-bundle, not to the room]. I can't bear it. I can't.

The Manager's 'I don't understand' is literal: he cannot grasp that for the Mother the past is not past — theatrical 'already happened' is irrelevant to her continuous torment.

THE MANAGER. But since it has happened already... I don't understand!

The Mother's longest speech refuses the past tense entirely: the torture is present-continuous, the children are anchors to it, and the Step-Daughter's flight is a second abandonment.

THE MOTHER *[the Child-bundle in one arm, the other hand on the Boy-chair — both children held at once; she does not move from her chair for the whole speech].* It's taking place now. It happens all the time. My torment isn't a pretended one. I live and feel every minute of my torture. Those two children there — have you heard them speak? They can't speak any more. They cling to me to keep my torment actual and vivid. But for themselves, they do not exist. They aren't any more. And she *[Indicating the Step-Daughter.]* has run away, she has left me, and is lost.

The Father names the asymmetry of their existence: he is pinned to one shameful moment while she is freed by it — his appeal to the Manager is a plea for proportional justice.

THE FATHER. The eternal moment. She *[Indicating the **Step-Daughter.**]* is here to catch me, fix me, and pin me forever to that one shameful moment of my life. She can't give it up. And you, sir, cannot fairly spare me it either.

The Manager's response converts the Mother's anguish into a dramaturgical pivot point — 'nucleus of the whole first act' — demonstrating his compulsive reduction of pain to structure.

THE MANAGER. I never said I didn't want to act it. It will form, in fact, the nucleus of the whole first act right up to her surprise. *[Indicates the **Mother.**]*

The Father reframes punishment as inevitability, using the word 'passion' to aestheticise guilt and position himself as a tragic figure rather than an agent of harm.

THE FATHER. Just so! This is my punishment: the passion in all of us that must culminate in her final cry.

The Step-Daughter's physical staging of her own memory — head on breast, eyes closed, vein visible — is simultaneously a wound and a performance; she commands her mother's cry as a director would.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. I can hear it still in my ears. It has driven me mad, that cry. You may put me on as you like — fully dressed, if you like — provided I have at least my arm bare. Because, standing like this *[She leans her head on the Father's breast.]*, with my head so and my arms round his neck, I saw a vein pulsing in my arm here; and then, as if that live vein had awakened disgust in me, I closed my eyes like this, and let my head sink against his breast. *[Turning to the Mother.]* Cry out, mother. Cry out as you did then!

The Mother's intervention is the play's most purely maternal moment: she separates them bodily, names the relationship ('my daughter') and hurls accusation at last, her silence finally broken into rage.

THE MOTHER *[coming forward to separate them].* No! My daughter, my daughter! *[And after having pulled her away from him.]* You brute! you brute! She is my daughter! Don't you see she's my daughter?

The Manager's satisfied retreat toward the footlights — the direction of the audience — marks the instant he stops being a collaborator and becomes a spectator; the professionals and the suffering have briefly aligned.

THE MANAGER *[walking backwards towards the footlights — the way a satisfied audience member would, if a satisfied audience member could walk].* Fine. Fine. Damned good. And then, of course — curtain.

The Father's excitement confirms his deepest need: he wants this moment certified as having really happened, because theatrical validation is the closest he can get to absolution.

THE FATHER *[going towards him excitedly].* Yes, of course, because that's the way it really happened.

The Manager's conviction is aesthetic, not moral; his pleasure is at having found the right curtain-line, which he and the Father enjoy for entirely different reasons.

THE MANAGER *[convinced and pleased].* Oh, yes, no doubt about it. Curtain here, curtain!

*At the reiterated cry of **The Manager**, **The Machinist** lets the curtain down, leaving **The Manager** and **The Father** in front of it before the footlights.*

The Manager's irritated explanation — curtain as signal, not command — shows the theatre's codes are not shared; the gap between symbol and literal action will prove fatal later.

THE MANAGER. The darned idiot! I said "curtain" to show the act should end there, and he goes and lets it down in earnest. *[To the **Father**, while he pulls the curtain back to go on to the stage again.]* Yes, yes, it's all right. Effect certain! That's the right ending. I'll guarantee the first act at any rate.

Act Three — The Question

PART I — THE TRAP

When the curtain goes up again, the two-level set of Act Two has been struck. The stage is empty except for a single short fountain basin set centre, its walls high enough that nobody can see inside. The **Mother** is sitting on the right, the Child-bundle in her lap and the Boy-chair leaned against her knee. The **Son** is on the same side, but away from the others. He seems bored, angry, and full of shame. The **Father** and the **Step-Daughter** are also seated towards the right front. On the other side (left) are the **Actors**, much in the positions they occupied before the curtain was lowered. Only the **Manager** is standing up in the middle of the stage, with his hand closed over his mouth in the act of meditating.

The Manager reasserts command after philosophical overload, performing confidence he doesn't quite feel — the shrug is the tell.

THE MANAGER [shaking his shoulders after a brief pause]. Ah yes: the second act! Leave it to me, leave it all to me as we arranged, and you'll see! It'll go fine!

The Step-Daughter maps the power dynamics in one breath: she entered against the Father's will and the Son's, making her own agency the only honest force.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Our entry into his house [Indicates **Father**.] in spite of him... [Indicates the **Son**.]

Impatience masking anxiety — the Manager needs the Characters to stop owning the room and let him do his professional job of packaging their pain.

THE MANAGER [out of patience]. Leave it to me, I tell you!

She demands the record show her dissent, protecting herself from any future accusation that she colluded in her own humiliation.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Do let it be clear, at any rate, that it is in spite of my wishes.

The Mother's first eruption: not argument but a slow involuntary shake — grief too old for words, released in punctuation rather than speech.

THE MOTHER [from her corner; the head shakes by itself, slowly, twice]. For all the good that's come of it...

The Step-Daughter weaponises the Mother's suffering, converting family ruin into a ledger of guilt she can keep billing the Father.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER [turning towards her quickly]. It doesn't matter. The more harm done us, the more remorse for him.

The Manager's triple repetition betrays that he doesn't understand at all — he is placating, not absorbing, desperate to move on.

THE MANAGER [impatiently]. I understand! Good Heavens! I understand! I'm taking it into account.

The Mother raises the Child as both shield and witness, her plea aimed at posterity as much as the Manager — she needs history to know she tried.

THE MOTHER [the Child-bundle held high against her chest so that her own face is half-hidden by it]. I beg you, sir, to let it appear quite plain that for conscience' sake I did try in every way...

The Step-Daughter hijacks the Mother's testimony to redirect it as an indictment — and revels in the Son's cold distance as proof of the Father's damage.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER [interrupting indignantly and continuing for the **Mother**]... to pacify me, to dissuade me from spiting him. [To **Manager**.] Do as she wants: satisfy her, because it's true! I enjoy it immensely. Any how, as you can see, the meeker she is, the more she tries to get at his heart, the more distant and aloof does he become.

The Manager tries to enforce theatrical time against the Characters' pull toward their private tribunal — the second act is already losing to the real wound.

THE MANAGER. Are we going to begin this second act or not?

The Step-Daughter asserts dramaturgical authority, insisting the story's geography is hers to dictate, not the Manager's to simplify.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. I'm not going to talk any more now. But I must tell you this: you can't have the whole action take place in the garden, as you suggest. It isn't possible!

A bare prompt — the Manager wants a practical answer but is about to receive an ontological one.

THE MANAGER. Why not?

The Step-Daughter grounds the argument in the Son's isolation, reminding everyone that shame lives indoors, not in a photogenic garden.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Because he *[Indicates the Son again.]* is always shut up alone in his room. And then there's all the part of that poor dazed-looking boy there which takes place indoors.

The Manager retreats to production logistics, using the mechanics of stagecraft to avoid the emotional logic the Characters keep asserting.

THE MANAGER. Maybe! On the other hand, you will understand — we can't change scenes three or four times in one act.

The Leading Man's nostalgia for fluid stagecraft is also a quiet dig at the Manager's rigidity — professional vanity dressed as history.

PLAYER 1 (AS LEADING MAN). They used to change scenes like that once. When theatres had more hands than rules.

The Manager's condescension toward old audiences doubles as condescension toward the child on stage — he cannot see the horror he is dismissing.

THE MANAGER. Yes, when the public was up to the level of that child there.

The Leading Lady defends theatrical convention as audience service, unaware she is about to trigger the Father's most desperate speech.

PLAYER 2 (AS LEADING LADY). It makes the illusion easier. The audience needs to know which room we are in. They aren't going to guess.

The word 'illusion' strikes the Father like a slap because it is the precise term that would reduce his family's lived agony to mere performance.

THE FATHER *[the word lands physically — he turns too quickly]*. The *illusion*. For Heaven's sake — don't say *illusion*. Please. Don't use that word. It is particularly painful for us.

The Manager's bewilderment is genuine — he inhabits a world where 'illusion' is neutral craft vocabulary, not a wound.

THE MANAGER *[astounded]*. And why, if you please?

The Father's triple insistence on cruelty is itself a performance of injury — he is already philosophising the pain into a shape he can control.

THE FATHER. It is painful. Cruel. Really cruel. And you should understand that.

The Manager tries to reclaim the word for professional use, unconsciously demonstrating exactly why the Father finds it unbearable.

THE MANAGER. But why? What ought we to say then? The illusion, I tell you, sir, which we've got to create for the audience...

The Leading Man's interjection is pride, not insight — he wants his craft credited but stumbles into the Father's trap.

PLAYER 1 (AS LEADING MAN). With our acting.

The Manager's neat formula 'the illusion of a reality' is meant to close the argument; instead it opens the abyss.

THE MANAGER. The illusion of a reality.

The Father's soft recovery is the composure-tell the frame warns of — he is about to turn the argument into a philosophical ambush.

THE FATHER *[recovering, voice softer]*. I understand. You, perhaps, do not understand us. Forgive me. For you and your actors, the thing is only — and rightly so — a kind of game...

The Leading Lady's indignation reveals how the professional theatre protects itself by treating art as serious work, not 'game' — she cannot hear the compliment inside the insult.

PLAYER 2 (AS LEADING LADY) *[interrupting indignantly]*. A *game*? We are serious actors, sir. We have training.

The Father gently rehabilitates 'game' as art, then pivots: their art creates the illusion of reality, but the Characters have no reality outside illusion.

THE FATHER. I don't deny it. What I mean is the game, or play, of your art, which has to give, as the gentleman says, a perfect illusion of reality.

The Manager's approving 'Precisely' is the last moment he holds the upper hand before the trap closes.

THE MANAGER. Precisely —!

The Father's unfinished sentence is a rhetorical grenade — he dangles the implication that their only existence is as illusion, daring the Manager to follow.

THE FATHER. Now, if you consider the fact that we [*Indicates himself and the other five **Characters**.*], as we are, have no other reality outside of this illusion...

The Manager turns to his Actors for support — collective bewilderment as defence against an argument none of them can counter.

THE MANAGER [*astonished, looking at his **Actors**, who are also amazed*]. And what does that mean?

The Father's turn toward the house and direct question to the audience collapses the fourth wall; the trap is for everyone, not just the Manager.

THE FATHER [*after watching them for a moment with a wan smile*]. As I say, sir, that which is a game of art for you is our sole reality. [*Brief pause. He goes a step or two nearer the **Manager** and adds.*] But not only for us, you know, by the way. Just think it over. [*Looks the **Manager** in the eyes. Then, slowly, turns out toward the house. A pause long enough to feel.*] Can you tell me who you are?

The Manager's confident tautology 'I am myself' is the exact ground the Father is about to pull from under him.

THE MANAGER [*perplexed, half smiling*]. What? Who am I? I am myself.

The Father halts mid-sentence — the pause is the argument; he lets the Manager feel the instability before naming it.

THE FATHER. And if I were to tell you that that isn't true. Because *you* and *I*...

Laughter as the first line of defence: the Actors mock what they cannot refute, and the Manager encourages it to re-establish hierarchy.

THE MANAGER. I should say you were mad —! [*The **Actors** laugh.*]

The Father names the trap openly, and the Actors' too-loud laughter proves his point — performance and reality have already blurred.

THE FATHER. You're quite right to laugh. We are all making believe here. So you can object that it's only a joke for that gentleman there [*Indicates the **Leading Man**.*] to play me — who am, on the contrary, myself: this thing you see. [*Quiet.*] You see — I've caught you in a *trap*. [*The **Actors** laugh — too loudly, too quickly.*]

The Manager tries to invoke procedural memory ('we've had this before') to escape a recursion he cannot win.

THE MANAGER [*annoyed*]. But we've had all this over once before. Do you want to begin again?

The Father drops the philosophy and presses directly — 'Who are you?' is no longer rhetorical; he genuinely needs the Manager to confront his own contingency.

THE FATHER. No, no. That wasn't my meaning. In fact — I'd like to ask you to abandon this game of art [*Looking at the **Leading Lady** as if anticipating her.*] which you are accustomed to play here with your actors. And to ask you, seriously, once again. [*Beat.*] Who are you?

The Manager deflects inward crisis outward by performing outrage for his company — social dominance replacing argument.

THE MANAGER [*astonished and irritated, turning to his **Actors***]. If this fellow here hasn't got a nerve! A man who calls himself a character comes and asks me who I am!

The Father distinguishes fixed character from fluid person with quiet authority — this is his most cogent moment, and the most self-serving: it justifies his own unchangeability.

THE FATHER [*with dignity, but not offended*]. A character, sir, may always ask a man who he is. Because a character really does have a life of his own, marked with his own particular features. Which is why he is always *somebody*. But a man — I'm not speaking of you now — may very well be *nobody*.

The Manager invokes institutional title as identity — rank as ontology, the last card of a man losing a philosophical duel.

THE MANAGER. Yes, but you are asking these questions of me, the boss, the manager! Do you understand?

The Father extends the argument into time, forcing the Manager to feel how today's self will look like illusion from tomorrow — vertigo as persuasion.

THE FATHER. But only to know if you, as you really are now, still see yourself as you once were — with all the illusions that were yours then. Think of those illusions, that mean nothing to you now, that don't even seem to you to exist any more. Don't you feel the very earth under your feet sinking, when you reflect that this you of today is fated to seem a mere illusion to you tomorrow?

Player 2's whispered question speaks for the audience: the meta-theatrical frame has dissolved; no one is sure of the boundary anymore.

PLAYER 2 [whispering]. Is this still the play, or has it become something else?

The Step-Daughter cuts through the Father's abstraction with one factual sentence — his 'reality' was always territorial and predatory, and she was the territory.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER [level, never raising her voice — colder than the philosophy]. His *reality*. He always knew exactly where to find me.

*A silence. The **Father** does not answer. He has, for once, no answer. The face changes before the body does. When he speaks again, the argument is no longer clean.*

The Manager's summary question — 'where does all this take us?' — admits he has been carried somewhere he didn't choose to go.

THE MANAGER [without having understood much, but astonished by the fast talk]. Well, well. And where does all this take us anyway?

The Father offers a symmetrical warning: your reality is as provisional as ours, so don't use our contingency as a safe weapon.

THE FATHER. Oh, nowhere. Only to show you: if we [Indicating the **Characters**.] have no reality beyond the illusion, you mustn't count too much on yours either — like yesterday's, it may be an illusion to you tomorrow.

The Manager tries irony as exit — suggesting the Characters claim superiority — but the irony misfires because the Father will simply agree.

THE MANAGER [determining to make fun of him]. Ah, excellent! Then you'll be saying next that you, with this comedy of yours that you brought here to act, are truer and more real than I am.

Two words of absolute, unironic conviction — the Father's certainty is more unsettling than any argument, because it admits no qualification.

THE FATHER [the greatest seriousness — no smile]. But of course. Without doubt.

The Step-Daughter's interruption is surgical: she translates the Father's metaphysics back into money and flesh, the afternoon in Madame Pace's room.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER [the same temperature; addressing the room, not him]. He was real that afternoon. With his hundred francs. He was very real.

The Manager's 'Ah, really?' is hollow — he hears surprise, not the accusation of rape that the Step-Daughter has just dropped into the room.

THE MANAGER. Ah, really?

The Father's mild reproach assumes the Manager was following — he mistakes theatrical engagement for genuine comprehension.

THE FATHER. Why, I thought you'd understand that from the beginning.

The Manager's question reduces the argument to a competition — who is more real — which is exactly the Father's point about the contingency of persons.

THE MANAGER. More real than I?

The Father leaves the conditional hanging — he doesn't need to complete it; the Manager's reality-changes are already conceded.

THE FATHER. If your reality can change from one day to another...

The Manager's defensive relativism is meant to normalise flux, but he is inadvertently confessing to having no stable self — the Father's position all along.

THE MANAGER. But everyone knows it can change. It is always changing, the same as anyone else's.

The Step-Daughter pre-empts the Father to deliver the sharpest blade: their fixity is not a boast but proof of what was done to them and cannot be undone.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[before the Father can answer — flat, precise].* His doesn't change. Mine doesn't either. He should know.

The Father's composure cracks under his own argument and the Step-Daughter's precision — he finds he has reasoned himself into his own prison: fixed, immutable, condemned to that afternoon forever.

THE FATHER *[the cry breaks; afterward the body goes still — not the composure he had at the start of this part, but a different stillness, as if he has just walked into the wall of his own argument she has just shown him].* No, sir. Not ours. Look here — that is the very difference. Our reality doesn't change. It *cannot* change. It cannot be other than what it is. Because it is already fixed. Forever. *[Quieter, the horror finding him.]* It's terrible. Ours is an *immutable reality*. Which should make you shudder when you approach us — if you are really conscious that your reality is a mere transitory and fleeting illusion, taking this form today and that tomorrow, according to your will. Illusions of reality. Represented in this fatuous comedy of life. That never ends. Nor can ever end.

PART II — THE REFUSAL

The Manager's patience finally cracks; he reasserts theatrical authority over metaphysical digression, reducing the Father's anguish to a scheduling problem.

THE MANAGER. Oh for God's sake, will you at least finish with this philosophising, and let's try and shape this comedy which you yourself have brought me here? You argue and philosophise a bit too much, my dear sir. You know you seem to me almost, almost... *[Stops and looks him over from head to foot.]* Ah, by the way, I think you introduced yourself to me as a — what shall we call it — a "character," created by an author who did not afterward care to make a drama of his own creations.

The Father's flat sincerity is itself provocative — he refuses irony, insisting on literal truth where the Manager expects a concession or a joke.

THE FATHER. It is the simple truth, sir.

The Manager's attack is double-edged: he distrusts the claim and distrusts the playwright it recalls, revealing his anxiety about the avant-garde encroaching on his stage.

THE MANAGER. Nonsense! Cut that out, please! None of us believes it, because it isn't a thing one can believe seriously. If you want to know, it seems to me you are trying to imitate the manner of a certain author whom I heartily detest — I warn you — although I have unfortunately bound myself to put on one of his works. In fact, I was just starting to rehearse it when you arrived. *[Turning to the Actors.]* And this is what we've gained — out of the frying-pan into the fire!

The Father turns the accusation of over-thinking into a defence of wounded consciousness — suffering earns him the right to reason; animals cannot.

THE FATHER. I don't know to what author you may be alluding, but believe me, I feel what I think; and I seem to be philosophising only for those who do not think what they feel, because they blind themselves with their own sentiment. I know that for many, this self-blinding seems much more "human"; but the contrary is true. For man never reasons so much, and becomes so introspective, as when he suffers — since he is anxious to get at the cause of his sufferings, to learn who has produced them, and whether it is just that he should have to bear them. The animals suffer without reasoning. But take a man who suffers and begins to reason about it — oh no, it can't be allowed. Let him suffer like an animal, and then — ah yes, he is "human"!

The youngest player votes with his feet in imagination; the intellectual impasse has pushed the ensemble from boredom into genuine unease.

PLAYER 1 *[low, to Player 3].* I would like to go home. Quietly. Now.

The Manager attempts to reclaim practical authority — time, actors, rehearsal — against the Father's expanding philosophical territory.

THE MANAGER [sharp now, no longer amused]. Sir — plainer. Shorter. We have actors here who'd like to know what they're being asked to play. Tonight, if possible.

The Father draws a line between two words the Manager treats as synonyms; the distinction is his only dignity, and he will die on it.

THE FATHER. I am not philosophising, sir. I am explaining.

The Manager refuses the distinction entirely, exposing the circular trap: any extended self-justification sounds like philosophy to a man who wants action.

THE MANAGER. Look here. Look here. You're off again — philosophising worse than ever.

The Father finally names the source — suffering — as justification for everything; the cry is not rhetoric but a symptom he cannot suppress.

THE FATHER. Because I suffer, sir! I'm not philosophizing: I'm crying aloud the reason of my sufferings.

The Manager appeals to professional convention as a weapon, making the Father's self-awareness itself the violation, the breach of theatrical decorum.

THE MANAGER [slaps the table]. I'd like to know if anyone has ever heard of a character who climbs right out of his part and makes speeches the way you do. Have you ever heard of such a thing? I haven't.

The Father inverts the power relation: authors follow characters, not the reverse — a claim that repositions him as subject, not object, of creation.

THE FATHER. You have never met such a case, sir, because authors, as a rule, hide the labour of their creations. When the characters are really alive before their author, he does nothing but follow them — he has to will them the way they will themselves. When a character is born, he acquires at once such an independence, even of his own author, that everyone can imagine him in situations the author never dreamed of.

The Step-Daughter punctures the Father's theory with a single knife-stroke of contempt; he performs authorship even while denying it.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER [quiet]. Listen to him. Even now he is the author.

The Manager's quick agreement is a way of closing a door — he wants to move on, not explore what the concession actually costs him.

THE MANAGER. Yes, yes, I know this.

The Father marshals the family as collective evidence, but his gesture toward the Mother and Step-Daughter reveals he still positions himself as their spokesman.

THE FATHER. So what is there to wonder at in us? To be born of an author's fantasy, and be denied life by him — answer me if these characters left alive, and yet without life, weren't right to do what they are doing now, after trying everything to persuade him to give them their stage life. We've all tried him in turn — I, she [Indicating the **Step-Daughter**.] and she. [Indicating the **Mother**.]

The youngest Player voices the room's paralysis — everyone senses something has gone wrong, but social hierarchy prevents anyone from acting on it.

PLAYER 3 [to no one in particular — the youngest voice in the room]. Should we — should someone — stop this? I keep waiting for one of you to say that we should. [No one does.]

The Step-Daughter's scene of twilight temptation is erotic and haunting; she reveals how deeply she wanted to exist, and how that hunger was also a kind of seduction.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. It's true. I too have sought to tempt him, many, many times — when he was sitting at his writing table, feeling a bit melancholy at the twilight hour. He would sit in his armchair too lazy to switch on the light, and all the shadows that crept into his room were full of our presence, coming to tempt him. [As if she saw herself still there.] Oh, if you would only go away, go away and leave us alone — mother here with that son of hers, I with that Child, that Boy there always alone, and then I with him [Hinting at the Father.] — and then I alone, alone, in those shadows. [A sudden movement, as if she would seize herself in the vision.] Ah! my life! my life! Oh, what scenes we proposed to him — and I tempted him more than any of the others!

Player 2's aside reduces the play's existential crisis to a complaint about verbosity — the ensemble's comic incomprehension is now its own small tragedy.

PLAYER 2 [to Player 1]. I had no idea Pirandello was so chatty.

The Father pivots from defending himself to blaming the Step-Daughter's excess for the author's abandonment — guilt-shuffling dressed as analysis.

THE FATHER. Maybe. But perhaps it was your fault that he refused to give us life: because you were too insistent, too troublesome.

The Step-Daughter rejects blame and offers an alternative: the author abandoned them out of artistic disgust, not because of her — she knows her own value.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Nonsense! Didn't he make me so himself? [Goes close to the **Manager** to tell him, as if in confidence.] In my opinion he abandoned us in a fit of depression, of disgust for the ordinary theatre as the public knows it and likes it.

The Son's sudden directness is a shock; he agrees not to help but to end the debate, aligning briefly with whoever might silence the Father.

THE SON [looking up, for once — directly at the **Manager**]. Exactly what it was, sir. Exactly that.

The Father moves to co-opt the Manager by volunteering to moderate both the Step-Daughter and the Son — a bid for control wearing the mask of reasonableness.

THE FATHER. Not at all! Don't believe it for a minute. Listen to me! You'll be doing quite right to modify, as you suggest, the excesses both of this girl here, who wants to do too much, and of this young man, who won't do anything at all.

The Son's single word is a wall; he will not be negotiated with, framed, or absorbed into the Father's managerial compromise.

THE SON. No, nothing!

The Manager turns the Father's own complaint back on him — a dry, professional verdict that the Father is as excessive as those he criticises.

THE MANAGER. You too get over the mark occasionally, my dear sir, if I may say so.

The Father's wounded surprise is revealing: he genuinely cannot see himself as others see him, which is the blind spot the whole play has been demonstrating.

THE FATHER [genuinely surprised, almost wounded]. I? When? Where? Give me one instance.

The Manager itemises the excess precisely — the character-claim, the philosophy, the sheer volume — giving the Father a mirror he refuses to look into.

THE MANAGER. Always! Continuously! Then there's this insistence of yours in trying to make us believe you are a character. And then too, you must really argue and philosophize less, you know, much less.

The Father stakes his survival on the right to narrate his torment; to strip that from him is not artistic editing but annihilation of his self.

THE FATHER. Well — if you take away from me the possibility of representing the torment of my spirit, which never gives me peace, you will be suppressing me. That's all. A man worth the name does not just live; he gives his own life a meaning. For me, this is everything. I cannot give it up — just to represent a mere fact, as she [Indicating the **Step-Daughter**.] wants. It's all very well for her. But I am not going to do it. It destroys my *raison d'être*.

The Manager's exasperation is comic but edged with real panic; neither character will yield, and the rehearsal is disintegrating in real time.

THE MANAGER. Your *raison d'être*! Oh, we're going ahead fine! First she starts off, and then you jump in. At this rate, we'll never finish.

The Father's apparent capitulation contains a condition — sacrifice must stay within bearable limits — which is no capitulation at all.

THE FATHER. Now, don't be offended! Have it your own way — provided, however, that within the limits of the parts you assign us each one's sacrifice isn't too great.

The Manager delivers his aesthetic credo: drama is action, not interiority — a principle the Father's very existence refutes.

THE MANAGER. You've got to understand that you can't go on arguing at your own pleasure. Drama is action, sir, action and not damned philosophy.

The Father accepts the rule while instantly qualifying it out of existence; he will argue exactly as much as his suffering demands, which is everything.

THE FATHER. All right. I'll do just as much arguing and philosophizing as everybody does when he is considering his own torments.

The Manager surrenders the philosophical argument and retreats to logistics — the scene is the only ground he can still claim as his own.

THE MANAGER. If the drama permits — which at this rate, sir, I doubt it will. For Heaven's sake, man, let's get along and come to the scene.

The Step-Daughter reminds the Manager of his own earlier constraint, turning his practical objection against him and defending the sprawl of their reality.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. It seems to me we've got too much action with our coming into his house. *[Indicating Father.]* You said, before, you couldn't change the scene every five minutes.

The Manager begins compressing the family's diffuse suffering into stageable units — the Boy's wandering is the first casualty of theatrical convenience.

THE MANAGER. Of course not. What we've got to do is combine and group all the facts into one simultaneous, close-knit action. We can't have it as you want, with your little brother wandering like a ghost from room to room, hiding behind doors and meditating a project which — what did you say it did to him?

The Step-Daughter's clinical precision — consumes, wastes — insists the Boy's deterioration is literal, not metaphorical; she will not let it be softened.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Consumes him, sir. Wastes him away. He has not eaten properly since we came into that house.

The Manager's tentative reconstruction shows him beginning to visualise the stage picture, moving from arbitrator to director without noticing the shift.

THE MANAGER. Well, it may be. And then at the same time, you want the little girl there to be playing in the garden... one in the house, and the other in the garden: isn't that it?

The Step-Daughter's description of the garden and the child is the one moment of unguarded tenderness she allows herself; it makes the coming loss unbearable.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Yes, in the sun, in the sun! That is my only pleasure — to see her happy and careless in the garden, after the misery and squalor of the horrible room where we all four slept together. And I had to sleep beside her — I, do you understand? — carrying everything I carried, next to her, with her folding me in her loving little arms. In the garden, whenever she spied me, she would run to take me by the hand. She loved the little flowers, and would show them to me.

The Manager physically moves the Boy-chair — a small gesture that marks his irreversible crossing: he is no longer judging the Characters but staging them.

THE MANAGER. Well then, we'll have it in the garden. Everything shall happen in the garden — we'll group the other scenes there. *[Calls a Stage Hand.]* A backcloth with trees, and something to do as a fountain basin. Good — you've fixed it up. *[To Step-Daughter.]* This is just to give an idea, of course. The Boy, instead of hiding behind the doors, will wander about here in the garden, hiding behind the trees. It's going to be rather difficult to find a child to do the scene with you where she shows you the flowers. *[To the Boy.]* Come forward a little. Let's try it. It's a nice business, this lad. What's the matter with him? We'll have to give him a word or two to say. *[He stands. He picks up the Boy-chair himself and walks it across the stage. This is the pivot of his arc: until this gesture he has been the audience, watching from a remove. From this gesture forward he is the audience's complicity made physical. He places the Boy-chair behind the fountain basin, where it is partly hidden by the rim. The audience must read the move land.]* Hide here — like that. Show your head a little, as if looking for someone.

The Step-Daughter uses the Son's presence as a practical excuse, but her real aim is to isolate and expose him — she knows his silence is its own performance.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. It's useless to hope he will speak, as long as that fellow there is here... *[Indicates the Son.]* You must send him away first.

The Son's eager acceptance is a trap he springs on himself; his readiness to leave reveals how desperately he wants to escape, which is the one thing he cannot do.

THE SON [jumping up]. Delighted! Delighted! I don't ask for anything better. [Begins to move away.]

The Manager stops the Son reflexively, driven by theatrical instinct — a missing character is a broken scene, whatever his personal rights might be.

THE MANAGER [at once stopping him]. No! No! Where are you going? Wait a bit!

The Mother gets up alarmed and terrified at the thought that he is really about to go away. Instinctively she lifts her arms to prevent him, without, however, leaving her seat.

The Son's plea is genuine panic beneath the dignity; he is discovering his own captivity in real time and it terrifies him.

THE SON [to **Manager** who stops him]. I've got nothing to do with this affair. Let me go please! Let me go!

The Manager questions the Son not out of curiosity but to force the articulation of a role — naming the connection is the first step to staging it.

THE MANAGER. What do you mean by saying you've got nothing to do with this?

The Step-Daughter's calm certainty is devastating; she has studied the Son and knows his refusal is performance, his departure impossible.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER [calmly — she knows him]. Don't bother to stop him. He won't go.

The Father names the Son's obligation clinically, reducing the coming scene with the Mother to a theatrical requirement — he weaponises the plot against his own child.

THE FATHER. He has to act the terrible scene in the garden with his mother.

The Son's stillness is a new register — not sullenness but a stripped dignity, the body's final refusal when words have failed.

THE SON [the body finally still — a kind of dignity arrives]. I will act *nothing* at all. I've said so from the very beginning. [To the **Manager**.] Let me go.

The Step-Daughter orchestrates the Son's entrapment with cold pleasure, demonstrating to the Manager that the family's bonds are gravitational, not chosen.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER [going over to the Manager]. Allow me? [Puts down the Manager's arm.] Well, go on then — go away. [The Son looks at her with contempt and hatred. She laughs.] You see? He *can't*. He is obliged to stay here, indissolubly bound to the chain. If I, who fly off when what has to happen happens, because I cannot bear him — if I am still here, supporting that face of his — you can well imagine he is unable to move. He has to remain. With that nice father of his, and that mother whose only son he is. [To the Mother.] Come on, mother, come along! [To Manager.] You see, she was getting up to keep him back. You can imagine how little she wants to show your actors what she really feels — but so eager is she to get near him that... There, you see? She is willing to act her part.

The Son accepts his imprisonment but withdraws consent — a distinction that preserves the last scrap of his autonomy even as it changes nothing.

THE SON [trapped now — and knowing it]. No. No. If I can't go away, then I'll stop here. But I repeat. I act nothing.

The Father asks the Manager to enforce what he himself cannot — revealing that paternal authority has completely collapsed and requires institutional substitution.

THE FATHER [to **Manager** excitedly]. You can force him, sir.

The Son's refusal is absolute and unadorned; he will not grant anyone — Manager, Father, theatre itself — the power to compel him.

THE SON. Nobody can force me.

The Father's claim to coerce his own son is a bluff and a horror simultaneously — the play is about to test whether that claim is true.

THE FATHER. I can.

PART III — THE FOUNTAIN

She seizes stage management from the Manager, choreographing the tragedy herself — her urgency signals she knows exactly how this must end.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Wait a minute, wait... First of all, the baby has to go to the fountain... [Lifts the Child-bundle from the Mother's lap and carries it to the fountain.]

The Manager's efficiency masks his ignorance; he approves blocking he doesn't understand, treating catastrophe as a staging problem.

THE MANAGER. Yes, yes of course; that's it. Both at the same time.

*The **Second Lady Lead** and the **Juvenile Lead** at this point separate themselves from the group of **Actors**. One watches the **Mother** attentively; the other moves about studying the movements and manner of the **Son** whom he will have to act.*

The Son weaponizes factual accuracy to refuse participation; correcting geography is his way of refusing emotional exposure entirely.

THE SON [to **Manager**]. What do you mean by both at the same time? It isn't right. There was no scene between me and her. [Indicates the **Mother**.] Ask her how it was!

The Mother's brevity confirms rather than argues — her words are a wound reopening, not a speech; she is incapable of rhetoric.

THE MOTHER. Yes, it's true. I had come into his room...

The Son's insistence on the room over the garden is a territorial defence: the garden is theatre, the room was real and private.

THE SON. Into my room. Do you understand? Not the garden. Nothing about this ever happened in the garden.

The Manager's dismissal of truth in favour of grouping reveals theatre's fundamental violence — it shapes reality to fit the frame.

THE MANAGER. It doesn't matter. Haven't I told you we've got to group the action?

The Son's challenge is not curious but threatening; he is acutely aware of being studied and feels his selfhood under attack.

THE SON [observing the **Juvenile Lead** studying him]. What do you want?

The Juvenile Lead's innocent denial only deepens the Son's paranoia — being watched without malice is somehow worse than being judged.

PLAYER 3 (AS JUVENILE LEAD). Nothing! I was just looking at you.

The Son reads the actress's interest as predatory mimicry, collapsing the distance between performance and violation of the Mother's grief.

THE SON [turning towards the **Second Lady Lead**]. Ah! she's at it too: to re-act her part! [Indicating the **Mother**.]

The Manager's cheerful gratitude exposes how completely he has missed the Son's horror — he mistakes surveillance for generosity.

THE MANAGER. Exactly! And it seems to me that you should be grateful to them for their interest.

The Son's long-suppressed outcry: the mirror speech is not philosophy but a scream against the unbearable self-consciousness of being staged.

THE SON [the cry he has been holding for the whole production — surprising himself]. Yes — but haven't you yet perceived that it isn't possible to live in front of a mirror? A mirror that doesn't only freeze us with the image of ourselves. It throws our likeness back at us — with a *horrible grimace*.

The Father's agreement is tactically self-serving — he validates the Son's anguish to neutralise the Son's resistance to re-enactment.

THE FATHER. That is true, absolutely true. You must see that.

The Manager moves the actors not out of empathy but stagecraft; he has finally found a blocking note he can execute.

THE MANAGER [to **Second Lady Lead** and **Juvenile Lead**]. He's right! Move away from them!

Flat withdrawal — the Son refuses even the satisfaction of a dramatic exit; negation is his only remaining act of autonomy.

THE SON. Do as you like. I'm out of this!

The Manager silences the Son and pivots to the Mother with professional briskness, treating her pain as exposition to be extracted.

THE MANAGER. Be quiet, you, will you? And let me hear your mother! [To **Mother**.] You were saying you had entered...

The Mother's gesture — hand at her chest — is the speech beneath the speech; her body holds what words can barely begin.

THE MOTHER. Yes. Into his room. I couldn't bear it any more. I went to tell him what I have inside me. All of it. [A hand at her chest, briefly.] But the moment he saw me...

The Son's denial is self-protective repetition: if he says nothing happened often enough, perhaps the guilt of doing nothing will dissolve.

THE SON. Nothing happened! There was no scene. I went away, that's all! I don't care for scenes!

The Mother validates the Son's version against herself, her habitual self-erasure offering him absolution he has not earned or asked for.

THE MOTHER. It's true, true. That's how it was.

The Manager presses for the scene not because it matters emotionally but because the plot requires it — he is filling a structural gap.

THE MANAGER. Well now, we've got to do this bit between you and him. It's indispensable.

The Mother's readiness is heartbreaking submission — she needs only a moment, a crack, to pour out what she has carried for years.

THE MOTHER. I'm ready. Whenever you are. If you could just find a moment for me to tell him what I have, here. *[Her hand at her chest.]*

The Father's rage at the Son is also guilt redirected: he cannot bear what his own decisions have cost the Mother he claims to protect.

THE FATHER *[going to Son in a great rage]*. You'll do this for your mother, for your mother, do you understand?

Two words, flat affect — the Son's refusal is so total it has passed through anger into something colder and more final.

THE SON *[flat]*. I do nothing.

The Father's physical shaking reveals the limits of his rhetoric; when philosophy fails, he resorts to the bodily force he usually dresses as reason.

THE FATHER *[taking hold of him and shaking him]*. For God's sake, do as I tell you! Don't you hear your mother asking you for a favor? Haven't you even got the guts to be a son?

The Son's counter-grip is a refusal to be shaken into feeling; the physical struggle externalises the internal war over who controls this story.

THE SON *[taking hold of the Father]*. No! No! And for God's sake stop it, or else... *[General agitation.]*

The Mother, frightened, tries to separate them.

The Mother's plea is wordless and desperate — she is not asking for peace, she is trying to keep her hands on what little remains.

THE MOTHER *[both hands on the Child-bundle, gripping it]*. Please! please!

The Father holds on past all persuasion — his grip on the Son is the grip of a man who needs the scene performed to justify his own suffering.

THE FATHER *[not leaving hold of the Son]*. You've got to obey, do you hear?

The Son's cracking voice betrays him even as his body refuses: invoking the absent author is a last defence, claiming the right to remain unwritten.

THE SON *[the voice cracking but the body refusing the cry]*. What does it mean — this madness you've got? *[They separate.]* Have you no decency? That you insist on showing everyone our shame? I won't do it. I won't. And I stand for the will of our author in this. He didn't want to put us on the stage. After all.

The Manager's indignant interruption is genuinely confused — he cannot process the Son's logic because his world has no room for unwilling characters.

THE MANAGER. Man alive! You came here...

Pointing at the Father, the Son performs the one act he allows himself: attribution of blame, a testimony that costs him nothing staged.

THE SON *[indicating Father]*. He did! I didn't!

The Manager's blunt question is unanswerable and he knows it — presence itself has become a trap the Son cannot argue his way out of.

THE MANAGER. Aren't you here now?

The Son's accusation is also a legal brief: he distinguishes fact from fiction to delegitimise everything the Father has performed as truth.

THE SON. It was his wish, and he dragged us along with him. He's told you not only the things that did happen, but also things that have never happened at all.

The Manager reduces the scene to procedural sequence, forcing the Son to narrate what he fled — testimony extracted by dramatic necessity.

THE MANAGER. Well, tell me then what did happen. You went out of your room without saying a word?

The Son's single-sentence answer turns his silence into a moral position; he avoided a scene then, and is still trying to avoid one now.

THE SON. Without a word, so as to avoid a scene!

The Manager's neutral prompt keeps the Son talking, exploiting the storyteller's momentum against the Son's every instinct to stop.

THE MANAGER. And then what did you do?

The hesitation and gloom signal the Son has arrived at the memory he cannot refuse — the garden walk is the last step before the horror.

THE SON. Nothing... walking in the garden... *[Hesitates for a moment with expression of gloom.]*

The Manager's gentleness here is almost predatory; he senses the reserve conceals something enormous and leans in like a director hunting the climax.

THE MANAGER *[coming closer to him, interested by his extraordinary reserve].* Well, well... walking in the garden...

The Son's 'horrible' is directed at the Manager but aimed at himself — he is about to be forced to witness, again, what he could not prevent.

THE SON *[exasperated].* Why on earth do you insist? It's horrible! *[The **Mother's** arms are empty — the Child-bundle is no longer in them, and she is the first in the room to feel its absence. Her hands close on nothing. She trembles, sobs, and looks towards the fountain before anyone has said why.]*

Three words, rising dread — the Manager has finally understood, and the question holds the entire weight of what the fountain means.

THE MANAGER *[slowly observing the glance and turning towards the **Son** with increasing apprehension].* The baby?

The Son's answer is the barest possible statement — he will not dramatise the drowning, but he cannot withhold it; geography becomes elegy.

THE SON. There in the fountain...

The Father's tender pity for the Mother is also self-distancing — pointing at her grief deflects attention from his own failure to prevent it.

THE FATHER *[pointing with tender pity to the **Mother**].* She was following him at the moment...

The Manager's anxious 'and then you' is the audience's held breath — he is no longer directing, he is dreading the answer.

THE MANAGER *[to the **Son** anxiously].* And then you...

The stage lights drop slowly, breath by breath, beneath the Son's narration. By the end of it, only the fountain's pale-blue interior and the bare bulb above the Manager's table remain. The Boy-chair is silhouetted behind the basin.

The Son finally surrenders the story in full — the image of the Boy watching his sister drown is what has been behind every refusal all evening.

THE SON *[the only continuous sentence he gives the room; he tells it because he cannot keep it inside any longer].* I ran over to her. I was jumping in — to drag her out — when I saw something that stopped me where I stood. The boy. Standing stock still. With a look on his face I will never forget. Watching his little sister, there in the water. *[The **Step-Daughter** bends over the basin and lowers the Child-bundle into it. The basin's walls hide the action from view. She sobs.]* Then... *[The fountain light holds for ten seconds on the silhouette of the Boy-chair behind the basin — the Boy watching. Then full blackout. Out of the dark, a revolver shot rings out from behind the basin where the Boy-chair is.]*

Lights snap back up at the cry that follows. The Boy is never seen dead — only the silhouette before, and the sound. What remains is the family, the company, the Manager, and the silence the audience has just been made to look into.

*The **Mother** does not cry out at once. She goes first to the basin and reaches down for the **Child-bundle** in the water; then, hearing the **Players** take up the **Boy-chair** behind her, she turns and reaches for that too. Her arms cannot hold both. The veil stays down over her face — she never lifts it herself, not even now. Only then does the sound come out of her.*

The Mother's double cry strips away every layer of performance — raw, ancient, maternal; the character and the wound are finally indistinguishable.

THE MOTHER. My son! My son! *[Then amid the cries and exclamations one hears her voice.]* Help! Help!

The Manager's question is half practical, half terrified; he is still trying to locate himself on the line between fiction and fact.

THE MANAGER *[pushing the **Players** aside while they lift up the Boy-chair and carry it off, handling it as if it were the Boy's body — heavy, careful, terrible].* Is he really wounded?

Two Players' announcement is both fact and theatre — they perform the news of death before they have processed it themselves.

TWO PLAYERS. He's dead! dead!

The Other Players cling to pretence as a life raft; the reassurance is for themselves as much as for anyone in the room.

THE OTHER PLAYERS. No, no, it's only make believe, it's only pretence!

The Father's terrible cry is his first uncontrolled moment — the word 'pretence' is the one wound no amount of philosophy can absorb.

THE FATHER *[with a terrible cry]*. Pretence? Reality, sir, reality!

The Manager's final exit is the play's truest act: not a decision but a collapse — he leaves because he no longer knows what theatre is for.

THE MANAGER *[no commentary, no irony]*. Pretence? Reality? *[He looks at the empty Boy-chair.]* To hell with it all. *[He turns and leaves the stage the way a man leaves a theatre.]*